The Politic

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# The Politic At 75

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# A Letter From the Editor

Dear reader,

In Yale classrooms that existed long before us, we have gathered: doing the arduous work of editing, of writing, of seeking to understand, of engaging in dialogue with openness and humility. In 1947, the founding editors of *The Politic's* predecessor resolved to create "a magazine of student opinion, presupposing that student opinion is worthy of separation from the attitudes of other groups and that it is worthy as well of attention and study."

The names of this publication have changed throughout its history, from the *Yale Political Journal: A Magazine of Student Opinion* to *Yale Political Monthly* to *The Politic.* And our world has changed too. New countries, conflicts, challenges, and triumphs have emerged in the past 75 years. But our mission of cultivating a space for engagement between students remains the throughline that unifies our past and present.

Seventy-five years ago and today, the work of *The Politic* is urgent, providing critical, unflinching analysis that meets the challenges of the world in which we live. To honor the writing and editing of Politickers past and present, we've assembled an evocative collection of stories, reminiscences, and characters for *The Politic's* 75th Anniversary Special Issue.

But first, we must admit something we discovered as we conducted our research and interviews for this issue: This may not actually be our 75th anniversary, after all. For years now, we've identified 1947 as the date of our (first) founding, but we learned that those who revived the publication in 1979 felt like their publication was something new. Only later, as a previous Politicker was writing our history, did the evolution of various campus political publications come together as part of one tradition. Rather than ignore our history or scrap the anniversary issue, we felt like this story said more than we ever could about our publication and about the legacies of every Yalie. It is within this context that we chose to include both present and past work in this issue. We want to show that our journalists today are writing and interviewing and designing as part of a long lineage of Yale students dedicated to long-form journalism.

Conrad Lee '25 asks us to weigh the price of silence and the price of dissent as he interrogates the spike in national security whistleblower prosecutions through the formidable Central Intelligence Agency analyst John Kiriakou.
Then, Aidan Stretch '25 takes us into the trenches of a different kind of war, exploring the use of the weapon of digital information to promote democracy and tyranny in different global contexts.

Turning from the battlefield of the digital information space, Honor Callahan '25 introduces us to Judge JoAnne Kloppenburg, unraveling myths of nonpartisan judicial election and contending with threats to the legitimacy of the courts. In an interview with former United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights Ra'ad Zeid Al Hussein, Leonie Wisowaty '25 and Hussein jointly consider power dynamics with the United Nations and the possibilities for a better, more equitable world.

These are just a few of the many important issues that our journalists are covering, analyzing, and honoring today. For our anniversary, Emily Tian '24 and Cameron Freeman '24 dug into our archives, looking at our coverage of issues like the Cold War, national security, and activism at Yale.

And finally, we spoke to our alumni to learn about their own experiences with The Politic and to see how the world has changed during their lifetimes. Noel Sims '24, Matthew Youkilis '24, Bryson Wiese '24, and Axel de Vernou '25 engaged in generative conversation with former contributors and editorial board members Robert Kagan '80, Jonathan Rauch '82, Gideon Rose '85, and Matthew Ellison '10.

We hope you pick up a copy of our special issue today or through the coming weeks. It is our most sincere hope that *The Politic* continues to be an innovative site for engagement and debate in the years to come.

Sincerely,
Isiuwa Omoigui
Co-Print Managing Editor

# THE PRICE OF DISSENT

BY **CONRAD LEE**

## National security whistleblower prosecutions have spiked since the Obama administration. Why?

**JOHN KIRIAKOU** bends over the webcam. He wears a black sweater that matches the top of his salt-and-pepper hair and the outline of his wide glasses. His manner is affable, but he speaks with the intensity that one might expect of a man who would risk imprisonment to leak state secrets to the press.

After joining the Central Intelligence Agency as an analyst in 1990, Kiriakou (pronounced Keer-ee-AH-koo) shuffled around the agency for seven years, but he found himself bored. "I wanted to do something really exciting," he remembered. On this impulse, he switched to counterterrorism operations in 1997. Four years later, in the aftermath of 9/11, he ventured to Pakistan, where he directed counterterrorism operations. Under his watch, the United States captured dozens of Al Qaeda fighters, including Abu Zubaydah, the presumed Al Qaeda third-in-command.

After stints at the CIA headquarters and the United Nations Security Council, and with five kids to care for, Kiriakou decided it was time to settle down. He resigned from the CIA in 2004, moved to Los Angeles, and took a consulting job at Deloitte.

But Kiriakou couldn't keep himself out of the crossfire. In December 2007, the New York Times reported a shocking new revelation in the CIA's torture program, by then known as "the worst kept secret in Washington." The agency had videoed the use of what officials called "enhanced interrogation techniques," which included waterboarding, sleep deprivation, and hooding, against Abu Zebaydah and other suspected terrorists before destroying the evidence three years later.

Kiriakou knew of the torture program but had turned down an opportunity to participate in it. He was passed over for promotion a month after that decision.

"The Deputy Director of Counterterrorism was an old buddy of mine, so I went in and said, 'Bruce, what the fuck! What, do I have to catch Bin Laden to get

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promoted around here?'" Kiriakou remembered. "And he's like 'well, the chief said that you were the only one who turned down the enhanced interrogation training' and that, these were his exact words: 'you displayed a shocking lack of commitment to counterterrorism.'"

Kiriakou says this incident led others to start calling him "the human rights guy" behind his back and that it was "not a compliment." But he knew of others who shared his thoughts on the program.

"I thought, 'Okay, great. I'm not the only person who thinks this is an abomination. Somebody is going to say something.' And nobody said a word," he told *The Politic*.

So Kiriakou decided to speak. Three years after he had retired from the agency, he confirmed what the Times had reported to Brian Ross from ABC News.

Kiriakou claimed that he did not leak "the CIA's dirty laundry" out of animosity. He felt he was defending the CIA's practices in the name of national security. And initially, there were no hard feelings. A Department of Justice investigation found no criminal wrongdoing. Two years later, when Obama took office, Kiriakou even joined the Senate Foreign Relations Committee as a senior U.S. Senate investigator for two and a half years.

**BUT THE GOVERNMENT'S** leniency would run out. In 2012, the CIA asked the Department of Justice to reopen Kiriakou's case. On April 5 of that year, he was indicted for violating the Intelligence Identities Protection Act and the Espionage Act, as well as lying to the CIA Publications Review Board. After first pleading not guilty, he took a plea deal and served 30 months in prison. He remains the only CIA agent involved in the U.S. government's torture program to be convicted of any crimes. The CIA did not respond to a request for comment.

Leaking U.S. government secrets is not a new phenomenon. As Jameel Jaffer, who directs the Knight First Amendment Institute at Columbia University and formerly represented Edward Snowden, remarked to *The Politic*, "If you look at today's *New York Times* or *Wall Street Journal,* the front page will include multiple stories that contain classified information provided by government sources."

However, Kiriakou is not an ordinary government source: He disclosed information on suspected government wrongdoing, making him a whistleblower. This distinction typically would afford Kiriakou legal immunity, but national security whistleblowers are exempt from the safeguards of the Whistleblower Protection Act. Instead, they are governed by the Intelligence Community Whistleblower Protection Act, which does not protect against retaliation or criminal prosecution, according to a 2013 Brennan Center factsheet on whistleblowing. This caveat has allowed the United States government to continue charging whistleblowers in the intelligence sector.

Gabe Rottman, an expert on the history of government leak investigations, directs the Technology and Press Freedom Project at the Reporters Committee for Freedom of the Press. He noted that the Intelligence Identities Protection Act, to which Kiriakou which was used to prosecute Kiriakou, "is one of the few federal statutes that explicitly criminalizes the public disclosure of truthful government information." It has only been used successfully for two convictions; Kiriakou's case is one of those two.

Kiriakou was also accused of violating the Espionage Act, which has only a slightly longer case history with whistleblowers. Rottman explained that the law, enacted during World War I, was built on prior legislation that protected defense and military institutions. "The initial intent behind it was to get at traditional espionage, the peo-

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ple selling secrets for money or ideological reasons, and for most of history that's how it was used," he said.

But this changed in the 2000s. Before former President Barack Obama took office, there had only been three prosecutions of whistleblowers under the Espionage Act. During his two terms as president, there were eight. This is inconsistent with Obama's public stance on whistleblowers, where he has lauded the "courage and patriotism" of whistleblowers and claimed their actions merit legal protection.

In Jaffer's words, "[After 9/11] the government started using the Espionage Act not just against spies as conventionally understood, but against government insiders who provided information to the press, with the purpose of informing the public about government abuse of one kind or another. The Bush administration really got that practice off the ground, but the Obama administration was arguably even more aggressive."

Rather than looking back to Bush, Rottman sees Obama's inauguration as the beginning of the uptick in prosecutions of journalistic sources, a term that refers to all leakers to the press and includes whistleblowers. Including the eight Espionage Act cases, he counts 11 journalistic source prosecutions during Obama's presidency, more than all previous administrations combined. (By his count, there were nine more through the Trump presidency.)

Jaffer claimed that increased efforts to prosecute whistleblowers present a problem. "Once you start using the Espionage Act against journalistic sources, you really make it much more difficult for reporters to do the work that the public needs them to do… The only possible check on government abuse is an informed public, and whistleblowers are crucial [in this regard]," he continued.

Jaffer explained that suppressing whistleblowing extends beyond prosecuting whistleblowers themselves. He drew attention to the shift from charging sources criminally under the Espionage Act to charging the publishers of their information. He notes that, under President Trump, WikiLeaks founder Julian Assange became the first publisher to be prosecuted under the act. While Assange's journalistic techniques differ from those of standard publications, Jaffer still thinks his case is a troubling sign.

He said, "There has always been this kind of line drawn between government insiders who leaked information to the press, and then the press itself… If you take seriously the proposition that publishers are liable under the Espionage Act when they publish classified information, then a great deal of what mainstream American newspapers do every day is criminal."

**IN CONTRAST** to Jaffer's broad defense of disclosing classified information, some officials argue that whistleblowers should not override federal decision-making on classification. One former Obama administration intelligence official who requested to remain anonymous felt that leakers who follow their personal moral convictions evade discourses on standard classification processes.

"The decision [to classify information] is one that should be made at a societal level, not an individual level. As a society, we determined to delegate authority to classify the information to certain agencies and individuals within the government… Lower-level people who don't necessarily have the full picture shouldn't be the ones to say, 'Oh, I think the President of the United States was wrong here, so I'm going to reveal this information.'"

The intelligence official hints at an important point. Americans tend to glorify the rugged individual acting in the name of truth and justice against

the oppressive tyranny of government. In a country that has prioritized individual freedom since its conception, the increase in whistleblower prosecutions has little precedent. So what's driving it?

Rottman contended that officials classifying documents err on the side of caution and will often give documents a higher classification level than necessary. They have little incentive to not do so; erring the other way could have national security consequences for which they would be responsible.

Kiriakou was quicker to blame specific government officials. He singled out Obama and John Brennan, the Homeland Security Advisor when Kiriakou was prosecuted. "Most other presidents hate leaks that make them look bad and love leaks that make them look good. Obama just hated leaks, period," Kiriakou explained.

Kiriakou contended that Brennan helped Obama translate his animosity towards leakers into retaliatory action. He explained that Obama wanted Brennan to direct the CIA but encountered opposition from progressives who were concerned about Brennan's involvement in the Bush administration's torture program. In response to this discontent, the Obama administration appointed Brennan as Deputy National Security Advisor for Counterterrorism. In Kiriakou's view, this gave Brennan time to "get the liberals to back off" while he could curry favor with Obama by demonstrating his austerity with national security leaks.

Kiriakou claimed that his lawyer thought the CIA's case case against him was "shit, and they know it's shit." But Kiriakou felt the agency did not care.

"The goal was to ruin me. There was one CIA officer who was involved in my prosecution who very stupidly told a journalist, 'We're taking Kiriakou down.' They wanted to make sure that I paid a heavy price for airing the dirty laundry," he said.

The Obama intelligence official did not feel the uptick in whistleblower prosecutions was revealing of a policy shift. Instead, he saw two related factors creating the rise of cases: the ease in accessing and distributing classified documents in the electronic age and the digital footprints left in doing so.

"The combination of those two is what led to the increase of prosecutions in the Obama administration, rather than any policy decision that says we need to increase our prosecution of leakers," he said.

John Tye YLS '06 agreed with this assessment. Tye is a former Obama-era whistleblower who went on to found the nonprofit Whistleblower Aid. He dismissed the idea that Obama was responsible for the sudden spike. "I don't think that [the Obama administration] had an especially hard-line view on whistleblowers… I just think it was a lot of circumstance," he argued.

The intelligence official did admit that the Obama administration was guilty of "hand-wringing" with the problem of overclassification. As he explained, classification guides are massive, and using them to properly classify every document would be far too time-consuming. "If people follow the [classification] procedure to the letter, nothing would ever get done in government," he said.

However, the official was hopeful about the future of overclassification. He noted that the Director of National Intelligence, Avril Haines, recently stated that she intends to address the issue of overclassification. He also touched on the potential of artificial intelligence to determine classification levels. Although he acknowledged that there is concern about allowing a computer to classify national security information, he noted that studies suggest they can classify information better than humans.

**JAFFER THINKS** this is not enough. Although he noted that the Biden administration has yet to charge a journalistic source under the Espionage Act, he was dismayed that the current administration has not yet dropped the Julian Assange case or broadly reconsidered whistleblower prosecution policies. However, he still sees signs of improvement.

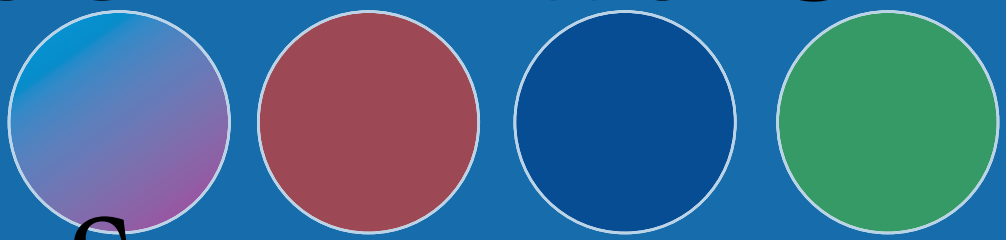
"I think that the experience of the Trump years has led many people who previously were very comfortable with unchecked executive power to be less comfortable with the idea. And some of those people are in the Biden administration."

He continued, "I hope that those people will use the authority they now have to put some limits on the use of the Espionage Act in a context in which there are real implications of the use of the act for press freedom and the public's ability to oversee the government."

Jaffer touches on an important idea: that the security of government secrets is fundamentally at odds with the public oversight that is essential for a healthy democracy. Overcoming that tension requires individuals who don't fear disobedience or nonconformity to disclose classified information. In the context of this country's reverence of freedom and individualism, it is only natural that America would respect the actions of these whistleblowers. But the recent rise in prosecutions does not reflect that sentiment.

An Andy Warhol print of the 1963 Birmingham civil rights protest hangs behind Kiriakou. "I always wanted it," he says. He holds his webcam up to the image and points out the key details. The German shepherd on the left is biting a man's leg while another shepherd lunges towards the man's arm. Surrounding the scene, on all sides, are policemen with batons. It is a poignant, evocative image, but it is also emblematic of the man to whom it belongs. As whistleblowers like Kiriakou see it, the price of dissent may be high, but the price of silence is far higher.

# Weapons of Mass Dissemination



## Open-Source Intelligence in War

BY **AIDAN STRETCH**

**ON JUNE 13, 2009,** hundreds of thousands of Iranians poured into the streets of Tehran to protest a corrupt presidential election. Over the next six months, the protests evolved from random demonstrations to a coordinated nationwide resistance to the Iranian regime. This outburst of political activism — known as the "Green Movement" — was driven by internet-based organizing. Iranian Internet usage jumped from 34% in 2008 to 48% in 2009, and mobile phone subscriptions increased from 59% to 72% of the population. Twitter posts and videos from citizen journalists chronicled the movement, expanding participation in Iran and at-

tracting international attention to the cause. For the first time, people within Iran and across the globe used online information to witness real-time developments, coordinate protests, and generate support for a grassroots opposition movement. Though ultimately unsuccessful — the Iranian regime eventually subdued the protests — the Green Movement marks a significant development in the use of the internet and social media in conflict.

The Iranian protesters used digital information as a weapon for democracy and freedom to be used against tyranny and corruption. Over the last decade, however, this weapon has been used most effectively not by democracies and freedom fighters but instead by tyrants and totalitarian regimes. Russia, in particular, has found success in spreading false narratives that have divided and destabilized Western powers. For example, in 2016, the Russians launched disinformation campaigns that affected both the presidential election in the United States and the Brexit Referendum in Britain.

Pointing to these examples and others, Asha Rangappa — a counter-intelligence expert and CNN national security analyst — told *The Politic* that Russia has maintained an asymmetrical advantage on the information battlefield in the past and that the West has been trying to play catch-up for a long time. But why has Russia had the advantage? Why are examples of social media being used in defense of democracy like in Iran exceptions to what has been a Russian-dominated information space? Rangappa believes the answers to these questions are rooted in the fact that "Russia approaches the information space as a battlefield, whereas the West largely has not." She explained that the West is used to "clear divisions between military and non-military action" and has not been accustomed to operating in "hybrid warfare."

But, in late February and early March of 2022, as Ukraine and its Western allies took to the internet to generate support and coordinate defense efforts in the face of a Russian invasion, Russia's chokehold on the information space loosened. Just as the Iranian protesters used Twitter to attract attention to their protests, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy used Twitter to attract attention to his own cause during the early part of the Russian-Ukraine war. As Russian forces moved into the outskirts of Kyiv in early March, Zelenskyy posted a video to his Twitter: "I am here. We will not lay down any weapons. We will defend our state because our weapons are our truth. Our truth is that this is our land, our country, our children and we will protect all of this." On the same day the video was posted, France reversed its policy on sending military aid to Ukraine and agreed to ship military equipment for the Ukrainian defense. To this, Zelenskyy responded via Twitter, "A new day on the diplomatic frontline began with a conversation with @EmmanuelMacron. Weapons and equipment from our partners are on the way to Ukraine. The anti-war coalition is working!" Zelenskyy's use of Twitter to galvanize international support for Ukraine, pressure countries to supply aid, and conduct diplomacy is one of the many ways Ukrainians have have instrumentalized social media in defense of their cause in the early part of this war.

Russia has acted no differently in the digital information space during the invasion than it has during past crises — Russian President Vladimir Putin has continued to disseminate false-narratives and sow confusion and instability across social media platforms and state media outlets. But, this time, the West has used *information* to push back against Russian *disinformation*. In the early part of this war, democracies are showing that they have finally learned how to approach the information space as a battlefield. Throughout their early successes, Ukraine and its allies have utilized not only Twitter and other social media platforms to generate public support, but also what is known as "open-source intelligence" or "OSINT" to track Russian movements and coordinate their defense. OSINT, as defined by the U.S. Department of Defense, is "intelligence produced from publicly available information that is collected, exploited, and disseminated in a timely manner to an appropriate audience for the purpose of addressing a specific intelligence requirement." This publicly available information used as intelligence has spanned from TikTok videos of Russian tank movements to satellite imagery of Russian missile strikes, which has allowed Ukraine and its allies to explain exactly what has happened with the general public.

**IN ORDER TO UNDERSTAND** more about the vital role OSINT is playing in Ukraine's digital information battle against Russia, it is crucial to understand the background and history of OSINT. While the internet has increased the amount of information available, OSINT is not a new concept. The methodical application of open-source intelligence began in the United States after Pearl Harbor in 1941. The U.S. Foreign Broadcast Monitoring Service (FBMS) institutionalized the method of monitoring domestic and foreign media during the Second World War. The practice then became embedded in the U.S. intelligence apparatus following the establishment of the CIA in 1947. Since then, two conflicts have reshaped the usage and value of open-source intelligence: the Cold War and the War on Terror. During the Cold War, both the Soviet Union and the United States relied heavily on open-source intelligence. According to former CIA analyst Stephen Merca-



do, OSINT became the "leading source of information" for U.S. intelligence during the conflict. The attacks of 9/11, coupled with the advent of social media, caused OSINT to be further integrated into U.S. intelligence efforts. The Intelligence Reform and Terrorism Prevention Act of 2005 required that U.S. intelligence services increase their use of OSINT and created the Director of National Intelligence's Open Source Center.

Since 2005, open-source intelligence and social media have together come to dominate modern conflict. Craig Nazareth, a digital information and intelligence expert at the University of Arizona College of Applied Science and Technology, told *The Politic*, "Government OSINT typically provides 90% of the intelligence used for policy-making and national security-related decisions." In Ukraine, Professor Zazareth explained, OSINT is playing an especially important role: "Journalists, social media users, and Ukrainian cell phone users at the front lines are capturing useful information that would not otherwise be available to U.S. drones or satellites." Tracking the evolution of OSINT in modern conflict up to its most recent usage in Ukraine provides insight into how digital information has changed warfare and how democracies across the world can use it to their advantage in the future.

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In 2011, Nathaniel Raymond, a human rights and communication technologies expert who lectures at the Jackson Institute for Global Affairs, conducted an operation known as the Satellite Sentinel Project in South Sudan. His objective was to use satellite imagery in conjunction with field reports to examine mass atrocities being committed and prevent further atrocities by focusing the world's attention on the Sudanese conflict. Raymond and his colleagues at the Harvard Humanitarian Initiative examined satellite images of "tukuls" — round homes made of mud — in South-Sudan to see how many were being burned and destroyed. Through this satellite imagery, the project was able to evaluate the extent of mass atrocities committed, predict future attacks, and most importantly (but tragically) provide evidence of the digging of mass graves in anticipation of future mass killings.

This initiative marked the first time that a sustained public effort monitored security threats through satellite imagery with the aim of real-time deterrence of human rights violations. And, it is now being used again to track civilian destruction and atrocities in Ukraine. As Russians encircled the Ukrainian port city of Mariupol in early March, satellite images depicted fires and significant damage done to residences. These images have informed where officials send military aid, helped them to organize humanitarian relief efforts, and provided a window for the world into the atrocities being committed in Ukraine.

The Satellite Sentinel Project in Sudan, like the Green Movement in Iran, reveals more of the power of digital information as a weapon for promoting and protecting truth and democracy. But they are both isolated examples of success. What has made Ukraine a turning point in information warfare is not a single video, satellite image, or Tweet, but rather a coordinated, tactical, information campaign throughout the Russian military buildup and early part of the invasion.

So, what exactly has that looked like? What makes this a defining moment for the West in information warfare?

**IN EARLY JANUARY,** officials in the Biden administration stood before the American public and told them everything they knew about the Russian military buildup on the Ukrainian border. They were waging information warfare in a completely unprecedented way. Jake Sullivan, the National Security Advisor to President Biden, appeared daily on news shows, providing detailed descriptions of Russian troop movements, specific types of weapons, and training exercises. American officials even provided evidence of "blood supplies" being transported to the Ukrainian border to show that this buildup was far more than merely a precautionary measure or show of force.

Raymond contextualized the objectives of this American media campaign. There are, Raymond said, four important areas in which open-source intelligence and media information can be used by governments during a conflict such as the invasion of Ukraine: early warning, evidence collection of digital sources for future accountability, retrospective corroboration, and means assessment/logistics planning.

The Biden administration's digital information tactics, starting with the military buildup and continuing through the invasion fit into these categories and, strung together, comprise a clever and effective digital information strike on Russia.

The initial U.S. media transparency and "early warning" of Putin's intentions were crucial to the defense of Ukraine multiple ways. First, it thwarted Putin's ability to create false pretexts for the invasion and garner local and international support for a Russian attack. Because the United States repeatedly emphasized and provided evidence for Putin's plans to invade, it made it much harder for Russian state media to plant narratives of Ukrainian violence or antagonism as justifications for a Russian invasion. Second, it hardened the resolve of Ukrainians. Oleksii Antoniuk '24 is a Ukrainian student who is President of the Ukrainian House of Yale. On February 22, days be-

# American officials preemp
# Russian reflexive control –
# won a crucial battle in the

fore the invasion, he told *The Politic* that through the transparent presentation of the crisis, friends and family back home did not believe any of Putin's falsehoods, knew an invasion was coming, and that "Ukrainians were absolutely going to fight." A quick invasion and destruction of Ukraine were never possible because the people knew it was coming. Third, OSINT chronicling the military buildup and likely imminent invasion allowed countries across the globe to put themselves in a position to respond. The minute Russian troops crossed into Ukraine, Western nations imposed sanctions on Russia and increased military aid to Ukraine. In a matter of days, an unprecedented international coalition stood firm against Russia.

Though they may appear to be limited to hindsight, we can also see how the next two categories — "evidence collection" and "retrospective collaboration" — played a role early in the invasion. Everything that Putin is doing is being captured either by cell phones or satellites, and those cell phone videos and satellite images will exist in databases long after the invasion is over. This permanence of digital information makes it much harder for Putin to break international laws, commit atrocities, and then try to reframe his actions after the fact. For example, as a 40-mile-long Russian convoy moved slowly south towards Kyiv, the fusion of on-the-ground reporting and OSINT tracked its exact movements. Officials now have a record of every move the convoy made and every action it took. This digital record of the convoy and the war as a whole can and will be used to hold leaders accountable and ensure that history tells the true, complete story of the invasion.

The final category — means assessment and logistics planning — is where OSINT and digital information have most directly impacted the West's ability to influence the war. Agencies, whether they are foreign governments, humanitarian organizations, or NGOs, cannot get assessment teams on the ground during war but they still need to know what is needed where at what time. And for those objectives, they rely on OSINT. By examining Whatsapp texts, social media posts, phone traffic, and satellite imagery, humanitarian organizations have been able to follow the flow of refugees throughout Ukraine and provide aid where needed. On March 9, 40,000 Ukrainians were evacuated out of harm's way, according to a Facebook post from Ukrainian politician David Braun. And by examining real-time satellite imagery and on-the-ground reports, the Ukrainian military has known where to move troops and weapons systems most effectively.

Ukrainian allies have also been able to quickly determine the country's needs and meet them. The Dutch have sent rocket launchers for air defense. The Estonians have sent Javelin anti-tank missiles. The Poles and the Latvians have sent Stinger surface-to-air missiles. The Czechs have sent machine guns, sniper rifles, pistols and ammunition. The list of 20 NATO countries filling specific Ukrainian military needs goes on — and their ability to do so hinges on the data and information that they can collect in real-time.

Ukraine's use of digital information in each of these four categories has been tactical and impressive. But Raymond also pointed out, "Russia can and has been doing the same thing." And as we have seen, they have traditionally done it better than anyone else. But in the early part of this war, Ukraine has mounted a surprisingly strong military defense and the West has formed a surprisingly cohesive coalition against Russia. Can these early victories be attributed to factors outside of the digital information battlefield? Or are Ukraine and its allies truly learning from their previous mistakes and beating Putin at his own game?

Rangappa believes that, at least early in the war, the West really is "finally learning to fight the information war" against Russia. Rangappa said that this progress can be partially explained by how we approach the concept of "reflexive control," which she defined as "the ability to feed adversaries certain assumptions to get them to

# oted and neutralized — they had, in a sense, digital information space.

act in a certain way."

For the past decade, Russia has utilized online information to exact this reflexive control over its enemies, leading them to take steps that they think are in their own interests but that actually benefit the Russians. In February 2013, General Valery Gerasimov — Russia's chief of the General Staff — published a pamphlet titled "The Value of Science Is in the Foresight," in the weekly Russian trade paper *Military-Industrial Kurier*. Now referred to as "The Gerasimov Doctrine," the paper explains how the Russian military can utilize online information to exert reflexive control over enemy targets and level the warfare playing field with adversaries such as the United States and Britain who have more advanced militaries, technologies, and economies.

In Ukraine, the United States engaged directly with the Russian tactic of reflexive control — largely by employing Raymond's idea of "early warning." American officials preempted and neutralized Russian reflexive control — they had, in a sense, won a crucial battle in the digital information space.

**SO, WHAT CAN WE LEARN** from the successful Western engagement on the information battlefield in the early part of this war that might prove helpful in future information battles?

First, action beats reaction. Rangappa identified one weapon that is most effective in defending against disinformation campaigns: "the truth." But the challenge then becomes getting the truth out before the lies. In Ukraine, the West did this successfully — American officials delivered transparent, truthful messages to the public before false narratives gained traction. This preemptive information strike successfully neutralized Russian digital attacks and modeled how a timely delivery of truth can defend citizens against disinformation.

Second, ordinary citizens are now military targets. Another point that Rangappa stressed is that, unlike traditional warfare, civilians become military targets on the information battlefield. The primary objective of disinformation campaigns is to exact Geramisov's concept of reflexive control on civilian targets, coercing them to act in a way that helps their enemy. In addition to striking first, governments must also inoculate their citizens against these attempts at reflexive control.The general public needs to know how to authenticate videos, vet sources, and understand that when they share unverified posts online, they could be acting as unwitting agents in an information war.

Third, credibility is crucial. In his analysis of modern uses of OSINT, Nazareth noted that the information conveyed to the public is only valuable so long as people actually believe it. That is, preemptive information strikes and education on authentication and source vetting are only effective if people trust the government officials and media platforms reporting real, truthful news. A Gallup Poll in 2020 concluded that 9% of people in the U.S. trust their media "a great deal," 31% "a fair amount," 27% have "not very much" trust, and 33% have "none at all." To prevent Russia and other bad actors from exacting reflexive control over their targets, Western nations must establish credible lines of communication with the public. This means that politicians and partisan networks telling fibs and stretching truths are no longer just unfortunate parts of politics. They are, instead, a national security concern. It undermines the trust in the information the public receives and leaves them vulnerable to disinformation campaigns.

Ukraine is just one information *battle*. Understanding and improving in these three areas is what will win the information *war*.

# POLARIZ

# COURTS

## The Myth of Fairness in J

BY **HONOR CALLANAN**

**FROM THE NEWLY COED CAMPUS** of Yale University to bureaucratic offices in Botswana to a quiet state judge's office in Madison, Wisconsin, JoAnne Kloppenburg '74 has always sought to maintain a dedication to fairness and justice. Among the first women to graduate from Yale College, she earned a degree in Russian Studies and then worked in the Peace Corps before finally finding her niche in the Wisconsin Department of Justice's environmental unit. However, Kloppenburg's belief in the possibility of a truly just state legal system began to fade when she decided to engage with one of her state's largest myths of judicial fairness: nonpartisan judicial elections in Wisconsin.

Although justices technically run as nonpartisans in the Wisconsin elections, the last two decades have seen an intense politicization of the state's high court that threatens their independence.

Stepping up to prevent a politically-appointed judge from being able to run unopposed, Kloppenburg challenged David Prosser, an appointed interim judge on the Wisconsin Supreme Court, in his 2011 race."I think it's really important that people challenge incumbents because it's important, even though they're nonpartisan, for a judge to go around and talk to people and see what's on their mind and what concerns them," Kloppenburg said in an interview with *The Politic*.

However, the realities of "nonpartisan" judicial elections quickly tempered her optimism in the nonpartisan process and the democratization of justice. The day before the first 2011 primary, Republican Governor Scott Walker introduced Act 10, a controversial bill severely limiting union activity in Wisconsin that spurred months of protest in the capital. Suddenly, the race became about which judge would uphold or strike down Act 10. Outside interest groups poured money into the race, including at least 3.5 million dollars spent by conservative groups like Wisconsin Manufacturers & Commerce and Citizens for a Strong America, a PAC with connections to the Koch brothers, who wanted to keep Prosser on the bench to protect Walker's agenda. Millions of dollars worth of attack ads ran in the weeks leading up to the election – millions of dollars that Kloppenburg's publicly financed campaign could not match. Though some polls had put her ahead before election day, Kloppenburg lost her 2011 bid by 7,006 votes.

**IN THIS AGE** of deepening partisan cleavages, judicial experts point to these instances of intense political influence in a process intended to produce a set of independent, nonpartisan justices as signs that partisanship has crept into the supposedly impartial courts. They

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## Judicial Elections

worry that keeping policies and systems that were designed without considering these political influences will enable the deterioration of independent state courts.

Though judicial elections like Kloppenburg's 2011 run are obvious examples of partisanship permeating the judicial branch, other contemporary justice selection models are being reconsidered as partisan influence finds its way deeper into state courts. While some form of election is the most popular method – 21 states use either partisan or nonpartisan elections to choose their judges – the next most popular is the Missouri Plan, which 14 states currently employ. Under the Missouri Plan, the governor appoints a judge recommended by a nonpartisan commission who then has to stand for a retention election at the end of each of their terms.

However, as an infamous retention election in Iowa in 2010 showed, the Missouri Plan does not perfectly protect against operatives who seek to influence the independence of the courts in this deeply partisan age of politics. The year prior, the Iowa Supreme Court handed down a unanimous decision in *Varnum v. Brien* striking down the state's ban on same-sex marriage. Outraged interest groups against same-sex marriage organized a massive campaign in response, seeking to unseat the three judges who happened to be up for retention election the next year.

Marsha Ternus was the Iowa Chief Justice when the *Varnum* decision came down and was one of the judges attacked by conservative interest groups. Ternus and the other two targeted judges decided to not run a campaign in defense of their decision, not wanting to engage in the political battle. Ultimately, the out-of-state conservative and religious interest groups' aggressive campaigns were successful enough to unseat all three judges in the retention election.

After 17 years on the Iowa Supreme Court, Ternus now practices law and lectures on judicial independence, and she looks back on her time on the court with appreciation for her colleagues. Ternus emphasized that as chief justice, she was confident in her fellow justices, saying, "We were all committed to approaching each issue with an open mind and making decisions based on the rule of law." She now views the system more warily. While she has faith in the decisions of the current justices, she worries about judges who might bring preconceived notions to the bench.

As scholars reckon with disquieting displays of politics seeping into the court, they point to different cases as the turning point for state courts. Some

see the *Bush v. Gore* decision, which settled the recount dispute in the 2000 presidential election, as the moment when partisan interest groups first recognized the large role state courts could play in important political issues. Others in states with judicial elections see *Citizens United v. FEC*, the 2010 United States Supreme Court decision prohibiting restrictions on independent campaign contributions, as the key point in which interest groups could begin to use their money to influence elections. From states deep in the throes of partisan influence like Wisconsin to those more resistant to influence under the Missouri Plan, experts and activists are working to temper the ability of partisan interests to influence judicial makeup.

The Brennan Center for Justice, a nonpartisan law and policy institute out of New York University Law School, has been tracking the rise in judicial partisanship and seeking policy reforms to address these concerns. This work resulted in a three-year project published in 2018. Douglas Keith, a member of their counsel team and a specialist in elections and fair courts, spoke in an interview with *The Politic* about the short- and long-term policy reforms needed to return a better balance of powers.

After studying the trends in judicial partisanship, scholars at the Brennan Center decided on an extensive two-pronged policy recommendation: opting for appointment systems over elections and limiting judges to a single, lengthy term. "You obviously want high-quality judges, you want transparency in the selection process, you want some measure of democratic accountability," Keith said. In forgoing judicial elections, advocates are aware of people's mistrust in potentially biased methods like an appointment system. Acknowledging this, Keith and his team emphasize the importance of having a diverse, nonpartisan nominating commission with strict rules dictating appointee criteria. They further argue that limited terms would help remove justices' decisions from political pressures, a policy proposed by the State Bar of Wisconsin a few years back.

Keith and his team at the Brennan Center recognize the difficulty of changing an entire judicial selection system. But they still point to reforms that can limit political influence on judicial elections like public financing, the option Kloppenburg used to finance her first election.The law ensured that candidates who received 1,000 contributions of $5 to $100 at the start of an election period would get $100,000 in a primary and $300,000 in a general election but could not raise money themselves. Indeed, according to Kloppenburg, this policy often can encourage participation by female and Black judges, who, like herself, may not have family wealth or political connections on which to rely.

Public financing also limits judges' connections to campaign donors who may later appear before them in court. In these instances of judges presiding over cases involving past campaign donors, the Brennan Center recommends stronger recusal rules dictating when a judge should or must recuse themselves from a case because of a conflict of interest with one of the parties arguing the case. Despite having a system that provides the most connections between judges and campaign donors, Wisconsin's recusal rules are relatively weak. Notably, recusal rule changes can only be introduced and approved by the justices themselves, making them unlikely to occur. Thus, all activists can really do is offer recommendations; in 2017, 54 retired Wisconsin judges signed a petition asking for mandatory recusals from cases with campaign contributors of significant amounts of money. However, in a five to two vote, the justices rejected the petition.

Jay Heck, an activist who has spent the last 20 years as the director of Common Cause Wisconsin, a watchdog group that advocates for fair government reform, still remembers when the state was known as an exemplary example of judicial independence. When millions of dollars were spent in the 2007 and 2008 elections, he and his group worked to get the Impartial Justice Law that enabled the public financing option used in the 2011 election. However, to the dismay of Heck and fellow activists, Governor Walker and Republican legislators repealed the Impartial Justice Act shortly after the election, removing the public financing option. They also got rid of rules forbidding coordination between candidates and independent campaign groups.

**DESPITE HER LOSS** in 2011 and her overall disillusionment with her state's judicial system, Kloppenburg decided to run for Wisconsin Supreme Court again in 2016. This time, without the public financing option, she found that campaigning was even more partisan than before. Both sides again poured in millions of dollars to get their desired candidate on the bench, but because there was no public financing, interest groups' dollars were even more important than during her first run. And again, whether she liked it or not, Kloppenburg was associated with the liberal side of the election, and her opponent Rebecca Bradley was Republican-backed. Once again, Kloppenburg lost

"Political reform, it's an ongoing thing. It's not like once you do it, it's done. It's once you do it, you have to fight like hell to keep it."

# “The power of a person’s vote has been overridden by the power of money.”

her run for the state supreme court.

In light of divisive elections such as Kloppenburg’s, activists feel an even more pressing need to enact the policies that could curb some of this partisanship in courts as they take on closely-watched cases. However, the very prescient reality for state courts right now is that very little of this legislation is in motion. In fact, in some states, there is pending legislation to curtail the power of the courts to check the legislature. In North Carolina, for example, State House Republicans were threatening to impeach liberal state supreme court justices if they did not allow Republicans to aggressively gerrymander maps in 2021-2022. Additionally, throughout the country, gerrymandering has emerged as one of the most intense and political fault lines for state supreme courts in the past year.

As state legislatures and political analysts pore over the data from the latest census to see how they can reconfigure their maps, the partisan conflict has made approval of the maps in many states virtually impossible without the intervention of the courts.

Kloppenburg identified these redistricting cases as some of the most pressing legal questions that the courts face right now. She pointed out that this issue is especially significant in the state courts this year, as the Supreme Court recently handed over the power to oversee redistricting to the state courts; in 2019, the Supreme Court decided in *Rucho vs. Common Cause* that partisan gerrymandering was a matter too political for the Court to take on and relegated this oversight to the state courts.

As Wisconsin gears up for another decade as a battleground state, a partisan battle is occurring over how to draw the state’s voting districts. Democratic Governor Tony Evers proposed a map that gave Democrats more competitive districts than the Republican-drawn maps of 2011, and the state’s Republicans quickly challenged it. Unable to resolve their differences, the two parties turned to the state court to decide on a map. While the court recently approved Evers’ map, the Republican legislature is now attempting to appeal this decision to the United States Supreme Court, though it is unclear whether they will take up the case. Heck from Common Cause explains that it’s unlikely, seeing as the high court recently struck down similar appeals in North Carolina and Pennsylvania, cementing the power state courts possess now in this important process of democracy.

As they look to the future of fair courts in Wisconsin, Heck and Kloppenburg have some tempered optimism. Long-time activist Heck emphasizes that to keep a system of judicial elections going, Wisconsin needs policies of strong recusal and public financing to let the elections do what they’re supposed to do. But he knows that maintaining these policies won’t be an easy or finished battle. “Political reform, it’s an ongoing thing. It’s not like once you do it, it’s done. It’s once you do it, you have to fight like hell to keep it.”

**FOR HER PART,** Kloppenburg finally broke into the world of the Wisconsin state judicial system in 2012 when she won election to the Wisconsin Court of Appeals, the court underneath the state’s supreme court. She has found it to be the independent mix she desired of justices who represent the different parts of the state.

Though she entered her career in Wisconsin’s statewide justice system with optimism for independence and judicial elections’ power to deliver it, Kloppenburg now struggles to be able to look past the shortcomings of the system. She reflected sadly on the partisan-imbedded nature of the state courts.

“I am a firm believer in elections, but I came to the reluctant conclusion that because the power of a person’s vote has been overridden by the power of money, there’s been such a distortion,” she said.

The increased interest in state courts by partisan groups makes Kloppenburg worry about the corrosion of the fundamental principle of separations of power. While judicial bias is inevitable regardless of the selection process, she and other experts argue that current vulnerabilities of the courts allow partisan groups to exert their influence beyond partisan state capitals to cultivate this bias on state courts and make it work for their interests.

As the country continues in its path of increased polarized partisanship, the supposedly closed-off courts are not far behind. Activists, judges, and experts continue to work within the complicated systems and laws of state courts to make whatever progress is possible to prevent this influence, but often with only limited success. In a system in which the court’s enforcement relies on the trust of the people, this loss of independence from partisan politics threatens their legitimacy in the public’s eyes and, consequently, the court’s power to wield any power at all.

# A Convers with Ra'ad Zeid Hussein

BY **LEONIE WISOWATY**

*Ra'ad Zeid Al Hussein was Jordan's ambassador t Permanent Representative of Jordan to the United Na United Nations High Commissioner for Human Righ World House Professor of Practice of Law and Humar*

**WHEN YOU SERVED AS HIGH COMMISSIONER, YOU DISREGARDED POLITICAL AND DIPLOMATIC POSTURING AND WERE UNAFRAID TO EXPRESS YOUR OPINIONS OF A COUNTRY'S HUMAN RIGHTS VIOLATIONS. YOUR DIRECTNESS ELICITED CERTAIN AGGRESSIVE RESPONSES. FOR EXAMPLE, THE PRESIDENT OF THE PHILIPPINES CALLED YOU "AN IDIOT," NORTH KOREA CALLED YOU A "PLOT BREADING SCANDAL MONGREL," AND THE CHINESE CALLED YOU DISRESPECTFUL.**

The Russians said I was mad. Mentally unhinged. They said I was messianic. It speaks to the power of human rights. It works its way into the legitimacy or questioning of the legitimacy of a government. It's in that space between the people and the government. It's so immensely influential if you get it right. It's amazing that it hardly ever figures in business, literature, or the social sciences. You can spend most of your life and not really be aware of what it means. Until, suddenly, one day you go to use a banking card and you see your bank accounts have been zeroed or you experience a denial of service because of your ethnicity or religion or you're not this or that. Suddenly, you begin to realize how weak and vulnerable you are. That's when it dawns upon you. The example I use most is breathing. You breathe 22,000 breaths a day, and you don't think about it for one second. You would only think about it if someone was trying to strangle you, and then you knew if you couldn't breathe in the next three minutes you're done. Human rights are very much like that – you just take them for granted.

**IN 2017 YOU MADE A STATEMENT SAYING, "AFTER REFLECTION, I HAVE DECIDED NOT TO SEEK A SECOND FOUR-YEAR TERM. TO DO SO, IN THE CURRENT GEOPOLITICAL CONTEXT, MIGHT INVOLVE BENDING A KNEE IN SUPPLICATION; MUTING A STATEMENT OF ADVOCACY; LESSENING THE INDEPENDENCE AND INTEGRITY OF**

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*o the United States from 2007-2010, and ations from 2010-2014. He then served as ts from 2014-2018. Currently, he is a Perry n Rights at the University of Pennsylvania.*

**MY VOICE — WHICH IS YOUR VOICE." COULD YOU GIVE A LITTLE CONTEXT ON THIS STATEMENT AND MENTION IN WHAT SPECIFIC WAYS DO YOU FEEL THAT YOU OR THE U.N. HAD TO "BEND A KNEE IN SUPPLICATION?"**

The High Commissioner is nominated by the Secretary-General and then elected by the General Assembly. Once there is a selected applicant, there's this informal procedure where the applicant must get the approval of the Permanent Five members. There's nothing to say that this must be done, but it's sort of established. I knew that I would, after three and a half years, have no support from the Permanent Five. I think most of the General Assembly, if not all of it, would probably reject me. I actually believe that if you do this job right, you should not be reelected because you are pushing back against these countries, and you are being vocal about how they treat their own people. If I had sought reelection, I would have envisaged one of the permanent members, maybe all of them, saying to me turn down your voice and we will reelect you. That's why I refused to go on and bend a knee because I wasn't going to entertain a quid pro quo.

The irony is that there is no country with a pristine human rights record. Every country can do better, and there is no model country. Every country I went to, I would meet the human rights activists, and they would tell me what was happening inside it. You might find in some European countries, for instance, that have protections and laws for everybody, but when it comes to facts, those protections don't exist. Go talk to the migrant communities or communities of color, and almost every one of them will say they do experience racism on a day-to-day basis. Every country can do better, and they just don't like it of course when someone points out there is work to be done.

**SO, YOU MENTIONED THAT THE U.N. PROMISES SOVEREIGN EQUALITY TO ALL ITS MEMBERS, YET IT IS HARD**

**TO IGNORE THAT SOME COUNTRIES HAVE MORE POWER THAN OTHERS. HOW DO YOU BELIEVE THAT THE UN CHALLENGES OR PRESERVES THE POWER OF SUCH COUNTRIES, FOR EXAMPLE, THE PERMANENT FIVE?**

Clearly, the power of the Permanent Five is felt very keenly in New York at the UN headquarters, where the Security Council is. That's where there is a veto, as we saw the Russians do [recently] with Ukraine, so the influence is very much present in New York. In Geneva, it's not as keenly felt because you have the Human Rights Council and there's no veto there. You have much deeper integration of civil society, and there's a peer review system called the Universal Periodic Review, where every two or three months fourteen countries are reviewed by their peers. It's not perfect. We have a lot of problems when it comes to implementation, but it's the only system of its kind, and no one has pulled out of it. Countries don't dare pull out because no country wants to say that it has hurt its own people. It is immensely powerful like that.

**YOU SAID THE MODEL IN GENEVA WAS MORE SUCCESSFUL. DO YOU THINK THAT IT IS A MODEL THAT THE SECURITY COUNCIL AND OTHER PARTS OF THE UN SHOULD ALSO ADOPT?**

I belong to a group called the S5. Many years ago, in 2005, we were five small countries that felt we would attack the use of the veto. We called ourselves the S5 to differentiate ourselves from the Permanent Five. The position was very simple: when there are credible and ongoing reports of inner atrocity crimes being committed, the permanent members would voluntarily desist from using the veto. It would be unconscionable not to take action because one country decided to didn't want to when so many people are suffering.

Most conflicts that we have are human rights violations that turn into conflict. If you want to prevent the conflict, the thing is to deal with the human rights violations that exist in the country. That requires a little bit of confrontation, and the U.N. doesn't like confrontation. That's why the human rights machinery and system are so different from the rest of the U.N.

It's so easy for someone to criticize the conduct of another country. We can sit here and talk about the actions of the Congo and the horrific violence that women in the eastern part of the Congo experience. But, if we were in the Congo, as Congolese, and we were critical we could easily be thrown in jail and thrown into horrible conditions. Would we do it then? It's always easy to criticize the other. It's the hardest thing to criticize your own community. When you think about human progress or social progress, every advance in society comes from a minority that says "enough." Enough. It may have been part of the tradition or part of a business plan, but we're not going to go along with this anymore. It starts with just a handful of people.

**WHERE DO YOU SEE HOPE THAT WE CAN MAKE THE WORLD A BETTER AND MORE EQUAL AND PEACEFUL PLACE?**

I mean it's the human side. One of the things I worry about is that there's so much emphasis on data and a robotic, mechanical-like world. I worry about the educational system churning out these incredibly gifted experts, technical experts, but people without a conscience. I keep saying to each class that I teach that we don't really need brilliant people. We have so many brilliant people. We don't have enough courageous, brilliant people.

Yesterday, I was talking to this medical scientist, and I said that last year we were celebrating Andrei Sakharov. Sakharov was this amazing nuclear scientist working for the Soviet Union, who decided to speak out. He used his status, his elevated status, to speak about the repression of the Soviet Union. You look around the world today and scientists are held in high esteem, so why don't they speak up? Why is it always journalists and nonprofits, and why don't the scientists say anything? I think what concerns me is that our education, if it's not tied to something else, can be almost next to useless. Yes, you can be a great technical expert and can find your way into the job market, but there has to be something else in life.

So it's the human side of people. What do you see people do on an everyday basis that gives you hope, and the realization that we're fundamentally good people. We like to help, and we like to be kind. We can become scared and frightened, and when we come scared and frightened, things switch off, and then we are capable of cruelty. I think then we have to be extremely careful.

One of my predecessors, Sergio Vieira de Mello, was recently killed in Baghdad in 2003. He said fear is a very bad advisor. You cannot run your own life based on fear. I think he was absolutely right. Even with the brutal attack on Ukraine, the pandemic, and climate change. You feel that we are overcoming the pandemic and we can overcome climate change, so, yes, I have hope.

# From The Politic Archives

Cameron Freeman and Emily Tian

The pages which follow draw extensively from *The Politic's* digitized archives and offer a lively sampling of campus perspectives across a 75 year timespan. They cover a selection of subjects that got *The Politic* — and the rest of the country — protesting, debating furiously, and taking to the page.

During these 75 years, what is now *The Politic* also underwent a number of iterations and lifecycles. First coming into existence as the *Yale Political Journal*, a magazine devoted to student opinion writing, it then was inactive for years before it was revived as the *Yale Political Monthly* in 1979 by now-historian and political commentator Robert Kagan. Variously renamed *The Yale Political Magazine* and *The Yale Political Quarterly*, the publication was formally rechristened *The Politic* in the fall 2001 issue, which placed student voices and opinions alongside guest essayists and authors like Crown Prince of Iran Reza Pahlavi and former U.S. Senator Gary Hart.

# The Cold War at 75

## 1947

### " WHAT ARE THE PROBLEMS OF KOREA, FOCAL POINT OF AMERICAN-SOVIET CONFLICT?" – WILLIAM S. GREEN

*Yale Political Journal Oct. 1947 Vol. 1 No. 2 (Ed. Charles Lichenstein)*

William S. Green's 1947 article on the U.S.-Soviet relations in the Korean peninsula appeared in the second-ever issue of the *Yale Political Journal*, *The Politic's* predecessor. Green outlines the brewing Cold War tensions in East Asia three years before the outbreak of the Korean War. Before the 1949 communist victory in the Chinese Civil War, American policymakers primarily positioned South Korea as a buffer against Soviet expansion. Cognizant of accelerating U.S.-Soviet competition, Green asserts the renewed importance of Korea as an area where the nations' spheres of influence abutted: "The people of the entire Far East are watching closely our actions in Korea. The success or failure of the U.S. economic policy, and the amount of cooperation between the United States and the Soviet Union in that country, will have an important influence on the history of the Far Pacific in the years to come."

## 1979

### "THE OIL TECHNOLOGY WEAPON IN U.S. — SOVIET RELATIONS" – NOEL LATEEF

*Yale Political Monthly Dec. 1979 Vol. 1 No. 2 (Ed: Robert Kagan)*

By the mid-1970s, the Cold War superpowers had retreated from the brink of nuclear conflict during the ephemeral detente era. As relations worsened towards the end of the decade, American policymakers considered new avenues for international cooperation and diplomatic coercion. In his 1979 article "The Oil Technology Weapon in U.S.-Soviet Relations," Noel Lateef YLS '83 (now President of the Foreign Policy Association) questioned the efficacy of export controls to achieve foreign policy aims. Presciently, he highlights the value of economic linkages to curtail the relationship's rapid decline, writing that "there is inadequate recognition that the development of economic relations with the Soviet Union could add an important stabilizing to the total relationship to the benefit of both sides." Lateef emphasized Soviet pride and warned against demeaning the adversarial nation: "It is important not to underestimate the value of status bargaining chips that can be traded for good behavior."

# 1994

## "PRESENT AT THE RE-CREATION: AN INTERVIEW WITH PAUL NITZE" – GAUTAM DUTTA

*Yale Political Monthly May 1994, Vol. 15 No. 3 (Ed. Gautam Dutta, Jeff Campione)*

*Yale Political Monthly* editor Gautaum Datta interviewed Paul Nitze in the magazine's May 1994 issue, the principal author of NSC-68, a classified 1950 document that laid the groundwork for the American policy of containment during the Cold War. Nitze, later a Secretary of Navy for Lyndon B. Johnson and chief negotiator to the Intermediate-Range Nuclear Talks, which culminated in the 1988 INF treaty with the USSR. Nitze, a Democrat, described Reagan administration's key contribution in hastening the collapse of the Soviet Union to be the "restoration of American self-confidence" — adding that his Russian friends were more affected by Reagan calling the Soviet empire the "Evil Empire" than anything else that happened. On North Korea's nuclear weapons, Nitze offered an overly bullish prediction, advising against negotiation in favor of waiting things out "because the internal economic situation within Korea is such that everybody is close to starvation."

# 2008

## "RUSSIA AFTER PUTIN: AN INTERVIEW WITH WILLIAM ODOM" — CHRISTOPHER GOMBESKI

*The Politic Spring 2008, Vol. 63 Issue 6 (Ed. Margaret Goodlander)*

Lieutenant General William Odom, who served as the Director of the National Security Agency under Reagan during a long career in military intelligence, mainly related to Russia, was interviewed in *The Politic's* Spring 2008 issue on Putin's Russia. At the time, Dmitry Medvedev, who would go on later to serve as president from 2008 to 2012 and prime minister from 2012 to 2020, was easily elected to presidential office, succeeding Putin. Medvedev, immediately following his victory, announced that Russia would reduce gas supplies to Ukraine, cutting in half all shipments to the country for several days. "Russia is going to use its oil monopoly politically," Odom said — a statement that rings as true today in 2022 as it did in 2008. Ultimately, Odom forecasts that the prospects of establishing a constitutionally liberal regime in Russia is "next to zero" and reports that he "would be surprised" should it be achieved in the next 30 to 40 years. "As long as the Ukrainians and Georgians and others continue to put up a fight against the Russians, I think the prospects for liberal change are much better," he said.

# 2018

## "EYES ON THE REVOLUTION: A PERSONAL ACCOUNT OF UKRAINE'S EUROMAIDAN MOVEMENT" – CHRISTINA FIGLUS

*The Politic May 2018 Issue 6 (Ed. Anna Blech, Sarah Donilon)*

Christina Figlus — a Ukrainian Yale student whose mother also served as Ukraine's Minister of Finance — offers a personal account of Ukraine's Euromaidan Movement for The Politic's May 2018 issue. In the fall of 2013, then-President Viktor Yanukvych was supposed to sign an agreement to put Ukraine on a path towards pursuing stronger relations with the E.U. His sudden policy reversal on November 21, 2013, led to spontaneous protests in Kyiv's Independence Square, which grew to be named the Euromaidan Movement. Figlus describes the ongoing violence of police and military forces against protestors, the administration's passage of anti-protest laws, and the continued determination of the movement's supporters. On February 22, 2014 — after 94

# The Long Decade of 9/11: Terrorism, National Security, and War In The 2000s

## 2001

### "THE GREAT LEAP BACKWARD: THE TRAGIC HISTORY OF MODERN IRAN"— FEREYDOUN HOVEYDA

*The Politic Nov. 2001 Vol. 1 No. 2 (Ed. Brian Wallach, Sam Yebri)*

The 9/11 attacks and the Global War on Terror brought renewed international attention to Middle Eastern affairs. Amid regional turmoil, outsiders wondered whether the conservative regime of the Islamic Republic of Iran, in power since 1979, would fall. Heightening crackdowns on reformers, students, and activists around the turn of the millennium seemed to confirm the precarious position of the Islamist government. In the second issue after The Politic was refounded in 2001, the editors solicited an essay from Fereydoun Hoveyda, Iranian ambassador to the United Nations from 1971-1979, and spoke to Reza Pahlavi, the exiled heir to the imperial throne. In his essay "The Great Leap Backward," Hoveyda questioned why the Iranian people had substituted the shah's tyranny for that of the repressive Islamist government. He attributed the slow pace of change to the "Iranian mindset," writing that the Ayatollah was the latest in a progression of strongmen. "Iranian rulers have always been autocratic and, more often than not, very cruel—a rule to which Khomeini was no exception. They can be compared to harsh paternal figures with absolute authority over their 'children.'" Pahlavi is the eldest son of Iran's last shah, one such tyrant. He expressed his hope for non-violent regime change led by young reformers. "I consider my role as one of a catalyst who can unite all Iranians around two common goals: the need for self determination and a secular democracy."

## 2003

### "THE ISLAMIC REPUBLIC AT 24: GROWING TENSIONS AND A DOOMED REGIME" — SHANNON O'PRAY

*The Politic Spring 2003 Vol. 4 No. 1 (Ed. Sam Asher, David White)*

As the United States' Global War on Terror expanded into Iraq in 2003, domestic instability continued to plague Iran. Pro-regime vigilantes and agents battled protestors. Security services arrested thousands of activists. Police opened fire on students calling for democratic reforms. Amid this precarious climate, The Politic featured "Iran: Stirrings of a Revolution" as the cover story for the Spring 2003 issue. Staff writer Shannon O'Pray '04 wrote on "The Islamic Republic at 24: Growing Tensions and a Doomed Regime." She expressed a belief that the protestors would imminently overthrow the Islamist regime. "In many ways, Iran's present situation resembles that of the final days of the Soviet Union." Tyler Golson '04 described the schism between the liberal attitudes among young Iranians and the regime's strict conservatism. "The masses of youth who fill the universities increasingly see America not as the 'Great Satan,' but as a 'Fortune Land' where anything is possible."

## "LIGHTS, CAMERA, ACTION" — CYRUS HABIB

2008

*The Politic Fall 2008 Vol. 62 No. 1 (Ed. Margaret Goodlander)*

The cover story for the Fall 2008 issue, "Calculating the Power Quotient: The United States & Iran in the 21st Century," demonstrates waning hopes for regime change in the Islamic Republic. Students pivoted instead to the future of US-Iranian relations, questioning the risks of nuclearization and proposing solutions for diplomatic cooperation. Cyrus Habib YLS '08 (later lieutenant governor of Washington) wrote that the U.S.-Iran divide could be bridged by a summit broadcast openly by radio and television in both nations. Habib argued that this transparency would force each country into genuine dialogue and incorporate the Iranian people as decision-makers. "Allowing them unfettered access to the broadcasted summit might encourage young Iranians to turn away from the political despair and apathy felt by many and toward a newly invigorated sense of engagement and awareness." Habib lamented that the Iran president had taken the chance to address Americans across media, including on CBS and at Columbia, while American policymakers contented themselves with elite dialogue. Iran had pushed for talks. Habib hoped Americans could employ that momentum to introduce unprecedented democratic accountability to the Iranian system.

## "PLOTTING THE NEXT MOVES IN OBAMA'S CHESS MATCH WITH IRAN" — SAM YEBRI AND JOSH LOCKMAN

2010

*The Politic Winter 2010 Vol. 63 No. 2 (Ed. Mathew Fishman, Edward Andrews)*

President Obama entered the White House in 2009 promising to end the wars in Iraq and Afghanistan and renew outreach to the Muslim world. This shift in Middle East policy opened the door to a new phase of relations with Iran, inviting speculation over the administration's approach, particularly to the Iranian nuclear weapons program. Nine years after his tenure as Editor-in-Chief of *The Politic*, Sam Yebri '03 collaborated with fellow attorney Josh Lockman '04 to recommend an uncompromising approach to sanctions against the Islamic Republic. In "Plotting the Next Moves in Obama's Chess Match with Iran," Yabri and Lockman mirrored Habib's calls for overatures to the Iranian people. Yet rhetorical support alone is not enough, they argue. "By implementing broader, so-called 'crippling' economic sanctions, the United States, in partnership with the EU and potentially Russia, must make the costs of developing nuclear weapons sufficiently high to outweigh the benefits of such a choice," they wrote. They argued that blocking Iran from aquiring nuclear weapons would prevent hardliners from achieving an unshakable grasp on the country, aiding democratic protestors. Yebri and Lockman argue Obama should walk a fine line between punitive sanctions, support for protestors, and negotiation. "Without a constructive US-Iran realtionship, there can be no stability in the Middle East."

# Yale Activism and Organizing Through the Years

## 1948

### "STUDENTS IN ACTION" — ROBERT SMITH

*Yale Political Journal Vol. 1 No. 3 Spring 1948 (Ed. Charles Lichenstein)*

Student activism seems sluggish here in the States, at least according to Robert Smith's 1948 article on activist movements in other countries. "Education here is easy to acquire, we tend to take it more for granted, and we consider less seriously the responsibilities which go along with it — of effective citizenship and leadership," the author writes, nearly seventy-five years ago (the same comment, penned today, would be likely received without so much a beat). Smith grants that the Second World War has generated a flurry of new student organizing and writes bullishly on the potential role of student government and formal representative organizations to effectively channel student opinion. He cites Aristotle's *Politics* at the end, suggesting the central role of education in avoiding tyranny in government.

## 1991

### "WE SHALL NOT BE MOVED: ANTI-WAR PROTESTS: TOLERANCE AND CALLOUSNESS" — ANDREW SULLIVAN

*Yale Political Monthly Vol. 12 No. 4 Feb. 1991 (Ed. Kimberly Kessler, Frederick Kagan )*

There is a long tradition of Cross Campus candlelight vigils, and on January 16, 1991 — marking the beginning of the Persian Gulf War, when President George H.W. Bush announced the start of Operation Desert Storm — students gathered to protest U.S. raids on Iraq. Someone built a replica in wood of the Yale WWI monument and draped it in a black veil, which the next day became the podium for an anti-war rally attracting about three hundred people that later moved to the steps of the New Haven Courthouse, when it joined another New Haven protest. Other demonstrators held a teach-in and extensive debates took place among students and faculty members. Andrew Sullivan, the author of a Feb. 1991 piece in *The Politic* describing the landscape of student organizing as tensions ran high amid the invasion, writes that he "was impressed with the level of discourse, the respect and tolerance shown for opposing points of view, and the sincere desire for peace as soon as possible."

## 1992

### "THE FIGHT FOR YALE'S FUTURE" — LINETTE HWU

*Yale Political Monthly Vol. 13 No. 4 May 1992 (Ed. Carlos Viana, Kimberly Kessler )*

Much of the May 1992 issue of the Yale Political Monthly is devoted to student responses for the Carew Report, a report released by a Faculty of Arts and Sciences Review Committee recommending budget cuts for the University in the form of faculty cuts, organizational changes, and delays to building renovations and repairs. The report also called for the total elimination of the linguistics and operations research departments, significant cuts in many other departments, especially engineering and sociology, and a reduction in graduate student enrollment.Carlos Viana, the magazine's editor, wrote a fierce and unequivocal critique of the report's recommendation, calling it a "threat to Yale College and the quality of life of its students for now and for many years to come." The plan was so controversial that it resulted in the resignation of then-Dean of Yale College Donald Kagan, who also warned in the pages of the magazine that "Yale's tradition and greatness are now threatened by a movement that aims to reduce it to the status of most other research universities, where undergraduate education is only one among many activities that are equally or even more important, perhaps to that of some where it is only an afterthought."

## 2015

### "WHOSE SIDE ARE YOU ON? THE RENAISSANCE IN STUDENT ACTIVISM" — JONATHAN COUTINHOANDREWS

*The Yale Politic, Spring 2015 Issue II, (Ed. Aaron Mak, David Steiner )*

Jonathan Coutinho, describing a confrontation between Fossil Free Yale divestment student protesters and administrators inside Woodbridge Hall in 2015, after which 19 students were given infraction tickets and threatened with arrest, summarizes an extended history of student protest at Yale, from the Black Panthers Trial in 1970 to the construction of an anti-apartheid shantytown in Beinecke Plaza in the '80s. Student frustrations sound hauntingly familiar to those of students today — much anger is directed at Yale Corporation, the University's governing body. Debate among student activists ranges on whether these movements are most effectively carried out outside of or within institutional channels like the Yale College Council.

## 2016

### "GRAD STUDENTS DIVIDED: INSIDE LOCAL 33'S STRUGGLE TO UNIONIZE" — KEERTHANA ANNAMANENI

*The Yale Politic, October 2016 Issue I, (Ed. Madeleine Colbert, Zachary Cohen )*

Keerthana Annamaneni charts the history of Yale graduate students' efforts to unionize in a Politic piece from October 2016. Local 33, a Yale graduate student organization still active today, sought recognition as a union in order to empower graduate students to negotiate the terms of their labor in research, lab and teaching projects. At the time, Local 33 was in the middle of a formal recognition process and sent petitions to the National Labor Relations Bureau asking for separate union elections in ten different departments. Dean of the Graduate School of Arts and Sciences, Lynn Cooley, said of the department election strategy, "It is an inappropriate and unfair tactic that raises serious questions about whether the union has the best interest of graduate students in mind." The portrait Annamaneni captures is ultimately one of a divided graduate student body, and some students and faculty members voiced personal misgivings of Local 33's campaigns.

## 2020

### "IN THE MAKING: A LEGACY OF ACTIVISM INSPIRES CLIMATE PROTESTS AT THE GAME" — IAN BERLIN

The Yale Politic, Feb. 2020 Issue IV, (Ed. Kaley Pillinger, Eric Wallach)

At the end of halftime during the annual Yale-Harvard football game, over 150 student, alumni and faculty protesters streamed onto the field in Yale Bowl to demand the University divest from its fossil fuels holdings and cut investment relationships with companies that hold Puerto Rican debt. Ian Berlin quotes student organizer Josie Steuer Ingall '24: "Disruption is necessary if you want people to not just go about their lives as if this is normal—because it's not normal." The high-profile protest drew coverage from most major news outlets across the country. However, as they face off an administration that has yet to satisfy student demands, Endowment Justice Coalition protesters have since shifted towards a coordinated legal campaign accusing the university of violating the Uniform Prudent Management of Institutional Funds Act, which sets standards for nonprofit endowment investing.

BY **NOEL SIMS**

*Robert Kagan '80 founded the* Yale Political Monthly *in 1979 and served as its Editor-in-Chief until he graduated. Kagan went on to work for the State Department under the Reagan administration. He advised John McCain on foreign policy during his 2008 presidential campaign and has been a senior fellow at the Brookings Institute since 2010.*

# A CONVERSATION WITH Robert Kagan

**WHAT INSPIRED YOU TO START THE *YALE POLITICAL MONTHLY?***

I felt that there was no publication where people were dealing with current issues in a serious way that had a bipartisan and open approach. I wanted to get a dialogue going on that didn't exist and I think that sets the *YPM* apart from other publications of the time, like the *Dartmouth Review*. Most universities then, and even more now, are predominantly liberal, so there wasn't a lot of tolerance for alternative opinions in the early 80s, and there's even less now I would say. Those of us who got the thing started, we didn't want to respond to the one-sided discussion by, you know, yelling and screaming from the other side. We just wanted to have a place where people were actually engaging each other. That was the goal.

**WERE THERE ANY PARTICULAR ISSUES AT THAT TIME THAT MADE IT ESPECIALLY APPARENT HOW ONE SIDED THINGS WERE?**

I'm really trying to remember what people were arguing about 40 years ago; it all seems very quaint, but it wasn't. A lot of the issues that people talk about now were not necessarily the front and center issues of the time. I mean, in those days, it was arms control and concern about the nuclear build-up on all sides. We were at sort of the height of the Cold War, so there was a lot of discussion about that, but there were also issues of education and whatnot. The *YPM* was a place to write thoughtful things about anything. I think that we covered a lot of different topics, and not all of them were necessarily political.

**DID YOU FEEL LIKE OTHER PUBLICATIONS WERE FOCUSED TOO MUCH ON A SPECIFIC AREA?**

No, it wasn't that so much. For one thing, I don't think there were that many publications on campus in those days. I mean, there was the *Yale Daily News*, obviously. There was the *Yale Literary Review* and those sorts of things that have been established forever, but there was nothing that was in that political and cultural

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realm, at least that I remember. You have to take into account my fading memory of these things.

**IT SEEMS LIKE YOU TOOK ON A PROJECT THAT WAS BRINGING SOMETHING REALLY NEW TO CAMPUS. WAS THAT SOMETHING THAT WAS AN INDIVIDUAL PROJECT? WERE YOU WORKING WITH OTHER STUDENTS? WITH MENTORS? WITH PEOPLE EVEN OUTSIDE OF YALE?**

No, it was very much a Yale student operation. We didn't have professors involved. We didn't have mentors. Back in the day, Yale was less *in loco parentis*; students were allowed to do what they wanted to for the most part, without any particular university involvement or guidance, so we were pretty much on our own. And it was really just me and a couple of my buddies, David Bechhofer and Peter Schultz. These were both freshmen roommates of mine, who were not particularly political, but they did a great job on design, distribution, editing, copy editing and all those things. It was a very small group of students with no real assistance, you know, selling ads to Yorkside Pizza to pay for it.

**AFTER YOUR TIME AS EDITOR AND GRADUATION, WHAT WAS YOUR RELATIONSHIP TO THE PUBLICATION?**

As long as I still knew people, I was sort of involved. But it's a matter of how much involvement the people who are running it want from other people. I mean, the answer is not much, right? So whoever is running it, it's their show, right? We certainly haven't been heavy handed about institutionalizing things as a publication, and I think it's still true. I mean, it's really about what the people who are at Yale at the time want. But I was always very satisfied with the direction it was heading.

**I NOTICE THAT THE DREAD PIRATE ROBERS APPEARS IN THE MASTHEAD MAYBE 10 YEARS AFTER YOU STARTED THE *YPM*, AROUND THE LATE 80s WHEN KIMBERLY KESSLER AND YOUR BROTHER FREDERICK KAGAN WERE EDITING. DO YOU KNOW THE STORY BEHIND THAT?**

So they are now married and I think my sister-in-law and brother were just very big *Princess Bride* fans. You'd have to ask him.

**RESPECTABLE. IT'S A GREAT MOVIE. MOVING FORWARD TO TODAY: DO YOU FEEL LIKE THIS ISSUE YOU IDENTIFIED WITH PUBLICATIONS ON CAMPUS — OR IN OUR POLITICAL CULTURE IN GENERAL — IS STILL PRESENT? IS THERE NOT A SPACE FOR BIPARTISANSHIP, OPEN DISCUSSION?**

Well, look, there's obviously debate on campus. I just don't feel like the two sides are that interested in engaging each other in actual arguments. Do you know what I mean? There's a lot of yelling and protesting on both sides. And there's a lot of, I would say, mutual intolerance, but obviously, it's still a predominantly liberal world. I'm sure conservatives on campus feel somewhat beleaguered. It seems that our society hasn't accomplished what the *Yale Political Monthly* was, in its very, very, very small way, designed to accomplish. Civil discourse on difficult topics is just not the trend of the world today.

**DO YOU THINK THAT THE WAY TO WORK TOWARD THAT CIVIL DISCOURSE IS THROUGH PUBLICATIONS LIKE [THE *YPM*]? IS THERE A NEED FOR SOMETHING BIGGER? IS THE ANSWER BOTH?**

Sure. I don't know what "something bigger" would be. But I do think that the *YPM* is a worthy activity insofar as anybody on campus is trying to create a civil discourse among competing points of view. In the present cacophony I'm sure it feels like it's getting drowned out. But I still think it's worth keeping the flame alive. For all we know, current events are gonna drive people toward a greater seriousness about civil

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discourse. In that case, it'll be a good thing to have publications and institutions that are there and ready to hash things out in a serious way.

**YOU MENTIONED EARLIER THAT WHEN YOU STARTED THIS PUBLICATION, IT WAS AT THE HEIGHT OF THE COLD WAR, AND TODAY WE'RE FACED WITH A SIMILAR SITUATION. WHAT DO YOU THINK THE ROLE A CAMPUS PUBLICATION IN CONNECTICUT AND IN THE UNITED STATES PLAYS IN THE DISCOURSE ON AN ISSUE LIKE THE WAR IN UKRAINE AND WHATEVER THE BROADER CONSEQUENcES OF THAT FOR THE ENTIRE WORLD WILL BE? BECAUSE I THINK IT'S CERTAINLY GOING TO HAVE A LASTING IMPACT ON JUST ABOUT EVERYBODY.**

I was recently on a college campus talking to students about this stuff. And it's obvious that there's a great deal of interest in what's going on. People come at things from a certain set of assumptions. And, now, I think a lot of people's assumptions have been upset by what's happened. My sense is that people are kind of grappling for a new paradigm, or a new way of understanding what this all means. It would be great if students had a chance to put down thoughts on paper because there's no better way to try to understand what you think. It's a great exercise to write in such a way that others will understand what you're saying, take your arguments, and decide what they think about them.

I think a lot of assumptions and paradigms have been shattered on a lot of issues over the past five or six years, so it's a very good time for people to be thinking out loud. And rather than assuming that you have nothing to say, what's better than starting to try to do that while you're still in college? After all, you're in, as we were, a heavy learning environment. You've got incredible resources; you've got professors to talk to about all these things. It's a very dangerous and in many ways, horrible moment, but it's also a very exciting moment. So I do think it's a good time to be writing the *Yale Political Monthly* or whatever you guys call it.

**AND THAT SPEAKS TO SOMETHING I THINK ABOUT A LOT AS A WRITER AND AN EDITOR, WHICH IS THAT WHAT IS THE ROLE IN GENERAL OF A CAMPUS PUBLICATION? BECAUSE WE'RE NOT BREAKING NEWS. AND WE'RE STUDENTS. WE'RE NOT FULL-TIME JOURNALISTS, AND WE HAVE NO MONEY. WE'RE NOT FLYING OUT TO THE BORDER OF POLAND TO SPEAK TO PEOPLE FLEEING WAR AND CROSSING THE BORDER. SO WHAT IS THE PURPOSE OF WHAT WE'RE SAYING? HOW DO WE CONTRIBUTE SOMETHING NEW?**

The university is a place where you can examine ideas and compare them to others. You read one point of view, whether it's in political philosophy or in the sciences, and you're going to be confronted with alternative points of view. You're learning how to evaluate these differences. And it seems to me that this is an opportunity to apply that learning — as well as the substantive learning in U.S. history courses or international relations theory courses — to the real world and to what's happening now. To me, that's an exciting prospect and when you get out of college it'll be harder to do in some ways. So this is a unique opportunity, in a way.

**I THINK THAT'S A REALLY GOOD PERSPECTIVE ON IT. AND DEFINITELY ENCOURAGING BECAUSE I THINK SOMETIMES IT FEELS, NOT PURPOSELESS, BUT JUST DIFFICULT TO CONTRIBUTE SOMETHING NEW TO THE CONVERSATION AS…**

…As a young person who only knows what they know. I know, I get that. But, you know, the people who do talk about it don't know as much about it as you may think they do. Just having the sort of courage to just put yourself out there is great and what's the downside? Somebody calls you a dummy. That's okay. And I think it's good to learn that. My personal prejudice, because I'm an old dinosaur, is that there's too much focus on Twitter, on short commentary and these little blasts of opinion. People feel like if they're not out there

on the internet, in some format, that nobody's going to be paying attention to them. So it's hard for you to write a piece for a print publication. It feels like "Oh my God, what is that? How many clicks am I gonna get on this?" But that kind of stuff, really, it matters more than we think it does. I mean, I still write long essays and books. That's basically all I do. And I think sometimes they penetrate through everything else. So I would encourage people to keep that particular aspect of writing alive.

**HOW DID FOUNDING THIS PUBLICATION AND THINKING THROUGH THESE ISSUES SHAPE YOUR PATH AFTER YOU LEFT YALE?**

My path after that was basically, with a brief detour in the government, writing essays about international relations and to some degree about politics. I didn't think I was going to necessarily be a writer when I grew up. But it certainly turned out to be an actual career path. I certainly didn't set out with that in mind in any real fashion. So I do think that I benefited. And I have to say it was a fun thing to be doing in college. It was a lot of work and you're up until four in the morning, but we had fun. And by the way we started printing stuff at the Pierson printing press. I mean, typesetting every single page by hand.

**HOW MANY ISSUES DID THAT LAST FOR?**

I think that lasted until we found a company that could print for us but I, I'm sure we put out a number of issues where David Bechhofer and Peter Shultz were running the prints at the Pierson printing press and stapling them together. It was like a kids show.

**HOW LONG DID THAT TAKE THE TWO OF THEM?**

I don't know. But it was definitely a crash for, you know, four days with very little sleep basically. But I mean, again, that's what college is for. Right? It's my second most important contribution to Yale.

**WHAT'S THE FIRST?**

My first most important contribution was the now late and lamented Pierson Inferno. I think the university in its ultimate wisdom canceled it. But it lived for 40 years. And that was also started by me and my two buddies, David and Peter. So that was a more significant contribution. But I'm still proud of the *Yale Political Monthly*.

"The university is a place where you can examine ideas and compare them to others."

# A CONVERSATION WITH
# Johnathan Rauch

BY **MATTHEW YOUKILIS**

*Jonathan Rauch '82 was a contributor to the* Yale Political Monthly *during his time at Yale and was a member of the* Yale Daily News *Editorial Board. Rauch has since worked as an author, journalist, and political commentator, during which time he has advocated strongly for issues including same-sex marriage and offered insightful analysis about the state of American democracy. He currently serves as a senior fellow at the Brookings Institution and a contributing editor of* National Journal *and* The Atlantic.

**WHAT DO YOU REMEMBER ABOUT THE *POLITICAL MONTHLY* WHEN YOU WERE AT YALE AND ALSO JUST CAMPUS IN GENERAL?**

In terms of the campus climate, it was amazing. Yale was a transformative experience for me. On the academic side, it was probably a 5.5 out of 5, it was off the charts good. And one of the reasons for that was the campus intellectual environment was quite adventurous. Most students were left of center. But they were liberal left. Not extreme progressive left. And everyone seemed accustomed to arguing. So you had David Frum who was a columnist at the *Yale Daily News*. He's now famous writer at *Atlantic*. He was kind of a conservative provocateur in that period, and that was great. People did not feel as constrained.

The biggest controversy, that was political, that was meaningful, when I was on the editorial board at the *Daily News* was the 1980 election. Ronald Reagan was the Republican. And at that point, he looked to a lot of people, including me, like a dangerously reckless, irresponsible, and extreme candidate. The Democrats were running President Carter, who was not super popular with the left and, needless to say, the right. He was increasing the defense budget and kind of governing from the center, maybe even more center right than center left. And there was a third candidate in the race, who was John Anderson, who was a Republican congressman from Illinois but who was a liberal Republican — those things still existed. He was running to the left of Carter, and student opinion was primarily for Anderson. So a notable controversy broke out on campus and in the pages of the *Daily News*, between my faction which believed that every vote for Anderson was, in fact, a vote for Reagan, and the other faction which believed that a vote for Carter might as well be a vote for Reagan. And that was a big debate. We had it in the *Yale Daily News* and my faction won, and the *Daily News* endorsed Jimmy Carter with all his flaws. And the reason I remember that is, no, I don't think it had any real world impact. But it seemed at the time, like a very important political proposition for all of us. We were encountering this not from the point of view of symbolic politics or cultural politics. We really thought it mattered who the president was in what and how Yale students voted. Most of them were voting in their home states, not Connecticut, so a lot of their votes were gonna really count. So I thought it was a very healthy political debate.

**TO WHAT EXTENT DID YOUR COLLEGE EXPERIENCE AND THE INTELLECTUAL RIGOR OF IT INFLUENCE YOUR CAREER PATH AND YOUR CAREER CHOICE?**

It was formative. When I arrived at Yale, I was more interested in music, but I didn't have the talent. And discovered, when I started writing for the *News*, actually reviews and essays, I discovered that I loved writing, and I was good at it. I was the co-opinion editor at the *News*, and also discovered that that terrain was very favorable. And that led me to an internship in Washington between my junior and senior years. And that led me to a journalism career which is still ongoing.

Equally important, the intellectual work that I did at Yale was this formative. I just published this past June a book called *The Constitution of Knowledge*, which is about how we find truth and the attacks on that: disinformation, cancel culture, all of that. And that work is a direct outgrowth of the work I did at Yale as an undergraduate on history of science, which is where I wound up focusing, which is really about how humans set up systems to make knowledge. I'm still drawing down the capital that I've earned at Yale. It was a remarkable place. It may still be like this. I hope so. But when I was there, a thing about Yale was that there was a lot of exposure to faculty, and undergraduates were expected to do, in many cases, graduate level work, and often did. And so it was a no compromise situation.

**HOW DID YOUR COLLEGE YEARS INFLUENCE YOUR POLITICAL VIEWPOINTS AND HOW DID YOU APPROACH POLITICS?**

So when I entered college, I was a Ralph Nader style liberal. And those are kind of scarce now. But those were people who believed that you had to tame giant corporations because giant corporations and monopolies were screwing consumers, and they very focused on having strong government good regulation. It's a little closer actually to Bernie Sanders-type progressivism than to woke progressivism, which is very cultural and very focused on race and not the economy. Yale taught me that things are complicated. Number one, because of Yale's emphasis on rigorous scholarship, which was heavily emphasized in my four years there, we weren't really allowed to get away with easy answers. I'm not just talking about modern politics. And that really imprinted on me that my mission was to try to penetrate and analyze and that if the answer was obvious, it was probably wrong. And that also carried over into my journalism, and is still my creed.

The other thing that happened to me at Yale is I encountered smart conservatives, particularly David Frum, who is a close friend. And these are people who — I thought I knew a lot, they showed me I didn't. They were saying things that seemed preposterous. But exposure to conservative thinking was not completely convincing and still isn't, but it was a sea change in my coming to respect the conservative worldview.

There were also Reagan advocates at Yale: There weren't many, but they were very outspoken and very smart. Conservatives at Yale — it was true then, it's probably true now — had to do a lot more work to defend their views. So they had read more. And that presented a great intellectual challenge. And then of course, you had the Reagan era, and that was unfolding. When I was there was the period when confidence in 1960s and 1970s style liberalism was in the process of collapsing as supply siders were fomenting an economic revolution. And Reagan was saying government is the problem, not the solution. It was a massive intellectual change. And conservatives in that era were where the intellectual action was happening. The opposite of what passes for conservatism today, which is anti-intellectual. You had the neoconservatives: people like Irving Kristol, *Wall Street Journal* editorial page. Reagan attracted people like Jeane Kirkpatrick. So that was a huge challenge. You had this massive insurgent intellectual movement that was unfolding. And that came to Yale too — Robert Bork was there. He's the extremely controversial Supreme Court nominee. So he was teaching at Yale. He was busy revolutionizing thinking about antitrust. So Yale was not a conservative place or libertarian place, but it was a place where conservatism existed and you just had to reckon with it. And that was the second big influence. When I got into Yale, I thought conservatives are kind of stupid. Libertarians are kind of weird. And when I left Yale, I thought: okay, this is a major intellectual movement.

I guess I'm gonna add something, which is the importance of Directed Studies in my case. As you know, Directed Studies is year-long exposure to the greatest that has been thought, and read in small groups with students who are particularly interested because it's selective. And that was my first encounter with the great ideas. Obviously, people like Plato and Kant and right up to the present, and Tocqueville. So in terms of shaping me politically, understanding America, the big ideas…I think, when I got to Yale when I was 17 and 18, I had the kind of understanding of America that you get from a civics course — you know, how to pass a bill and when the Civil War was. Yale gave me grounding in the big ideas on which our politics are still ultimately founded.

**CAN YOU BRIEFLY DESCRIBE YOUR WORK RELATED TO MARRIAGE EQUALITY AND EQUAL RIGHTS FOR QUEER PEOPLE? HOW CAN STUDENTS TODAY WORK TO ADVANCE THIS OR OTHER SOCIAL ISSUES IN A SIMILAR WAY?**

When the cause of same-sex marriage arrived in the mid-1990s, I recognized it as a potential breakthrough not only for legal equality but as a way to bring the benefits of family and community to homosexual people, especially the young. I myself didn't come out or even internally accept I was gay until I was 25, and part of the reason I struggled so hard against my true self was my knowledge that being gay meant I would never have marriage as a legal and social destination for my love. Having lived that trauma, I believed that the opportunity to marry could transform life for millions of gay and lesbian young people (and adults too, of course), while also strengthening the institution of marriage and making the country a better, fairer place.

I thought the work I and others were doing might pay off in a couple of generations, if we were lucky. Or never, if things went badly. The first 15-plus years were brutally disappointing and frustrating. We were all astonished when the breakthrough came. I still am.

There are lots of ways to advance justice, but they're not created equal. I agree with Mark Lilla that the contemporary left (especially in the university world) puts too much emphasis on protest and purism, and not enough on engaging the political system and making conversions in the movable middle, America's moral swing vote. I wish students would spend more time building victories in local politics and less policing pronouns.

My own path has been to operate primarily in the world of ideas by identifying and making the most persuasive arguments for the best policies. Ideas are like a big bomb on a long fuse: They take a long time to penetrate, but once they do, they can sweep all before them.

*Gideon Rose '85 served as the Editor-in-Chief of Foreign Affairs from 2010-2021 and managing editor from 2000 to 2010. He is now the Mary and David Boies Distinguished Fellow in U.S. Foreign Policy at the Council on Foreign Relations. While at Yale, he served as one of the first Editors-in-Chief of the* Yale Political Monthly.

# A CONVERSATION WITH Gideon Rose

BY **BRYSON WIESE**

**WHAT DO YOU SEE AS THE VALUE OF A PUBLICATION LIKE *FOREIGN AFFAIRS*?**

I just wrote an article on exactly that subject for a Department of Defense initiative called Project Minerva. The basic idea of a policy journal, a category that *Foreign Affairs* created in 1921, started out as follows. When Wilson took the U.S. into World War One, we were woefully unprepared, not just in terms of the military, but also in terms of diplomacy. The State Department could not possibly plan a peace along Wilsonian lines. And so Wilson created this special organization called The Inquiry. It brought together 150 historians and journalists and bankers and lawyers to staff the peace process for the postwar conference that they knew was coming.

They all went over to Versailles with Wilson, and Wilson fucks up Versailles. As Versailles ends, these guys say to themselves, "Oh, my God. On the one hand, this was a royal disappointment, because we don't have a good peace, nobody is going to join the league, and now our country is heading into isolation. But on the other hand, wow, this was a really good, interesting, fun, valuable exercise. We shouldn't just disperse. Let's try to keep the conversation going." And they did what people of their class did at the time, and they decided to form a gentleman's club devoted to the serious discussion of American foreign policy. Thus was born the Council on Foreign Relations.

After a little while, they thought, "We have to do outreach. How do we educate the public at large?" And so they created *Foreign Affairs* in 1922. The first editor was Cary Coolidge. His managing editor was Hamilton Armstrong. Coolidge died in 1928. Armstrong took over and then ran the publication all the way into the 70s — the first half century. He had an incredible influence. His model was a forum for discussion that is serious intellectually, but open to different viewpoints politically, and written in accessible language that anybody can understand. And the feeling was that this is an important part of democracy.

One-hundred years later, I think we've actually done a very good job at perfecting Armstrong's model. Technocrats love it because it provides a place where government experts and academic experts and independent voices can come together to discuss things in a calm, clear way. It's a classic liberal Enlightenment concept: rational individuals exposed to proper information and multiple points of view, having a reasonable discussion, and considering different options, which will, as a matter of faith, then yield better policies for the country and the world as a result.

I think the people in the policy journal world are doing as good a job as ever has been done. And yet, the government and the polity writ large is more divorced from serious technocratic thinking than it's ever been in my lifetime. Because the whole world and society around these little journals has gone crazy.

**HOW SHOULD TECHNOCRATS RESPOND TO POPULISM AND ANTI-ESTABLISHMENT TRENDS? DO THESE OLD FRAMEWORKS AND INSTITUTIONS HAVE TO BE REINVENTED?**

I was on jury duty once, and the judge's instructions were really impressive. He said, "Your job is very simple. It's to make a ruling based on these specific things that I am asking of you with regard to the specific bits of evidence you heard in the courtroom. Do your job well. And if you do your job well and I do my job well, justice is produced by the system, not by you individually." I have come to think of what we do along those lines.

Our job is to provide a good forum, to do the best we can to resist cognitive closure in any way, to polish our presentation so that it can reach as wide an audience as powerfully as possible. And as Tom Lehrer said about Wernher von Braun, "Once the rockets go up, who cares where they come down." "That's not my department," said Wernher von Braun. Our job is to put out the magazines, to sponsor good discussion, to walk the Enlightenment walk and not just talk the talk. And one hopes that the broader cultural trends swing back, but all you can control is what you do. The best way to fight the populists is to be a good liberal, and hope that the obvious virtues of your own approach, for which you are an ambassador, will prevail in the long run.

If you look at what's happening in Ukraine, it turns out that there are hidden strengths in democracies and being a good guy. When the bad guy does something like invade Ukraine, people realize, "Holy shit, we don't want that." You can rediscover the mundane virtues of systems that can seem boring and inefficient and ineffective when they're contrasted with a guy who comes up with a gun to your head and says, "Give me your country."

**HAS PUTIN ACHIEVED THE IMPOSSIBLE BY UNITING NOT JUST THE EUROPEAN UNION AND NATO, BUT AN ENTIRE COALITION OF WESTERN DEMOCRACIES? COULD THIS INVASION BACKFIRE FOR PUTIN OVER THE LONGER TERM?**

The first weeks of the invasion have been bad for Russia — very bad. Bad for Ukraine — very bad. But very good for us. The aggressiveness, the viciousness, and the recklessness of the assault surprised everybody outside the U.S. government. It galvanized a reenergized Western alliance in ways that all the jawboning in the world couldn't have. It's been a hysterical surprise to watch the German 180° flip. I mean, it's just astonishing. Nobody called that.The Biden administration has played this beautifully so far by not stepping on the storyline. If your opponent is screwing up, don't get in the way. In effect, Biden's team has done a good version of what Obama's administration infelicitously called "leading from behind" by letting the Europeans seem like they are coming to their own conclusions. Putin will have chosen a hot war in Ukraine and gotten a new Cold War with the West.

However, the biggest difference I can see now between "Cold War One" and "Cold War Two" is that during Cold War One, all the major economic powers were on our side. But that's not true now. What's interesting is who's in the other camp. China, India, much of the Middle East. These are very significant economic powers, who can, to some extent, blunt the impact of the sanctions and the exclusion that the old Western alliance is going to impose.

We seem to be heading into a new Cold War with a dominant world system run by us and our allies, just like the old days, from which Russia is

excluded. Although Russia will be allowed to sell energy, much like Libya in the '80s, and '90s, just on a much larger scale. But then, at the same time, there'll be a secondary, semi-illicit international system centered in Asia around China, in which the Russians will be able to be players.

What's going to happen with China is the most interesting angle on this. There is no reason to believe that China will fundamentally join the anti-Russian alliance or penalize Russia significantly. But they also don't want to get completely crosswise with everybody else. So the likelihood is they'll do enough to keep us from penalizing them. That puts Russia more under the Chinese thumb than they were. The result is a splintered world — in the global economy, in global geopolitics. But there will be semi-permeable membranes.

The underbelly of Eurasia — from the Middle East, through India, to China — is not interested in being completely dependent on Western global institutions that can cancel you. The countries that are not part of the 141 nations that condemned the Ukraine invasion at the UN are going, "I don't like what Russia did, but I don't want to be in a world in which anybody can be completely canceled like that." If you're a potential bad actor, or just an independent actor, and you're not really a full-scale member of the alliance, you don't want your freedom of action potentially curtailed.

**AT THE DAWN OF THIS NEW COLD WAR THAT YOU DESCRIBE, U.S. FOREIGN POLICY HAS PIVOTED TO SOME EXTENT AWAY FROM THE MIDDLE EAST AND TOWARD RUSSIA AND CHINA. BUT YOU HAVE A BACKGROUND IN MIDDLE EASTERN POLICY FROM THE NATIONAL SECURITY COUNCIL. DO YOU THINK THAT PIVOT AWAY FROM THE MIDDLE EAST IS WISE?**

Yes. Getting older is bad physically, but kind of fun intellectually. Because you see lots of stuff happen. And you realize that you can retrospectively judge various things.

The world for a long period of time was going to be dependent on fossil fuels. And the largest source of global reserves lay underneath not particularly nice countries in the Middle East. The question of how to keep the Middle East gas station open for the world was a pressing one. But now, the contribution of fossil fuels to climate change has only become clearer, and the timeframe in which the Middle Eastern energy resources will be necessary has come down a few decades.

So from my perspective, you did a lot of dumb things in the Middle East, but they were at least partly driven by the assumption that you had to stabilize it. And you tried various different ways to do so. From peace processes, to wars, to proxies, to whatever. And now several decades later, we can see that none of those things worked.

The region is still important, but dwindling in importance, and it won't be nearly as important in a couple more decades. So I don't see any particular reason to do much more with the Middle East now other than to play a modest balancing game that protects our core interests, without getting too deeply involved in local politics. I think the Iran deal was a little bit out of the business of direct management of Gulf security, and I would support that it was idiotic to leave it. It was working just fine for what it did. And generally, I've lost my zeal for domestic reform, I've lost my belief that we can do anything significant to affect the Israeli-Palestinian conflict. All these are heartbreaking realizations. But you know, there are some areas of the world are not yet ripe for development. And unfortunately, the Middle East has proven that over the last few decades. So you can't walk away entirely. But you don't have to be the central player, and you don't have to see it as the giant source of all threats. If I were, in Tony [Blinken]'s shoes, or Jake [Sullivan]'s, I'd say, "Okay, what is the least cost strategy for not having this region bother us as much as possible?" Don't expect any upside, just limit the downsides.

**YOU SAID THAT PRESIDENT BIDEN HAS MANAGED TO SUCCESSFULLY LEAD FROM BEHIND ON UKRAINE. HIS ADMINISTRATION'S HANDLING OF THE AFGHANISTAN EXIT WAS NOT VIEWED AS FAVORABLY BY MANY. HOW WOULD YOU RATE THE BIDEN ADMINISTRATION ON FOREIGN POLICY SO FAR?**

Going in, I was very high on the team. This is collectively the smartest, most serious-minded, most well-intentioned, most psychologically healthy, most emotionally aware and sensible group of people running American foreign policy in my lifetime. I know pretty much all of them. I'm friends with many of them.

So if we had just skipped to this winter, I would say, "Oh, the Biden administration is doing great on foreign policy, and I'm proud to associate myself with everything they're doing." But the first year had some more stumbles, with Afghanistan being the most notable. Last week, I bumped into an administration official. And I said, "Okay, you're doing this so well, why did you fuck up Afghanistan so much? What's

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the difference?" And he said, "Nobody expected Ghani to bug out at the absolute first sign of trouble." Even the Taliban didn't expect it. In Vietnam, the North Vietnamese did not expect to run to Saigon at the end as quickly as they did. They were surprised by the collapse. Everybody thought the Afghan government would hold out a little longer and make the retreat less chaotic.

Zelensky is proving to be the opposite. Nobody expected this former comic actor to become a global sex symbol, to become the heroic face of resistance. The Ukrainian leadership has performed as far above replacement as the Afghani leadership performed below. And one of the things that this tells you is that you can't always predict things because there are individuals who matter. You put Ashraf Ghani in Zelensky's position and you put Zelensky in Gandhi's position and maybe things look a little bit different each way.

That said, there's no way of looking at the Afghan thing without saying, "Why didn't you have better plans prepared for contingencies?" It was embarrassing and atrocious. The scariest part was that it was such an exact replay of Vietnam. It forced me into deep soul searching about what our field can accomplish. We replayed every single mistake from Vietnam. And came to the exact same conclusion. And if there's one thing my generation in the field learned with our mother's milk, it was how not to do another Vietnam. So to watch this play out was deeply soul crushing to me as a technocratic professional because it suggested there was no long-term learning that could've occurred because if there had been, it would have been on this fucking issue.

In the Biden administration's defense, the domestic politics of American policy was seen as the overwhelming priority by the administration during its first year. And I think correctly so. They were desperately trying not to do anything significant on foreign policy. The story was domestic, the story was COVID, the story was the economy, the story was immigration.

It is likely that the rest of the Biden administration's foreign policy tenure will be more successful. The one caveat is that I am worried by growing anti-Chinese sentiment in the country at large and the extent to which it's possible to generate a new "yellow peril." Watching the anti-Muslim furor sweep over the country after 9/11 was scary because it showed you what could happen when you combine real security issues with an easily and obviously "otherable" target. It's been scary to see how rapidly anti-China sentiment has picked up in the last several years. It's crucial that we separate out the real issues of U.S.-China policy, and the ongoing and enduring geopolitical rivalry that we are likely to have with China for the next several decades, from any kind of emotional or simplistic anti-Chinese sentiment or hysteria. There's no reason we are destined to be in a hot war with China and no reason that we can't at least try to address the real challenges that we have with them as technocratic professionals and sensible wonks, rather than heatedly emotional amateurs. The extent to which you already see a closing of debate on China, in the public and in Congress, and the extent to which the administration has contributed to that in some ways, and not necessarily pushed back on it, worries me. I think slipping into an overly hawkish, overly nonconstructive, anti-China bashing mode would be a grave danger mistake, which we will pay for in lost opportunities.

I would say that a former *Yale Political Monthly* editor Fareed Zakaria has written the best guide to how useless our old thinking is in approaching the new world. That's *Post Pandemic World*, which is a superb book. Basically, it tells your generation that pretty much everything now is up for grabs. And that's much scarier than the world that I grew up in. But it's also, in some ways, much more interesting and challenging. We have to come up with a whole new set of answers with a whole new set of players and a domestic environment that's much nastier than anything we had back in the day. How the hell we move forward? I certainly don't know. Nobody knows. And you guys have the fun and nerve-wracking challenge of figuring it out.

# hought, "We have to do cate the public at large?"

**TELL US ABOUT THE *YALE POLITICAL MONTHLY.***

After the '60s came the '70s, and there was a dearth of good, serious political discourse from the center right. A bunch of magazines emerged to put forward non-leftist ideas. It ran all the way from crazy institutions like the *Dartmouth Review* to centrist foreign policy journals to the *YPM*. Bob Kagan and my brother Joe Rose started the modern version of *YPM*. We didn't trace our lineage back all the way to 1947. We saw it as "Bob and Joe starting something."

The magazine was very small and very dependent on the editors and their close circle of friends for all the work. We had a big shot board of names that we just sort of hoped nobody would ever check up on. We never used them for anything, except for validation. And they probably didn't even read it. But we sent them copies once in a while.

We tried to give ourselves a veneer of seriousness. My father paid for a *Foreign Affairs* ad and a Foreign Policy Association ad. And so the back cover was an ad for *Foreign Affairs*, and the inside front cover was an ad for the Foreign Policy Association's Great Decision series. And then we just used the images afterwards for every single issue without being paid, and probably completely illegally, just because it made us look classier. It's very funny that I ended up becoming the editor of *Foreign Affairs*. We literally stuck that ad in the back.

I remember trying very hard to get advertising money, which is always what you want. I was the worst salesman in the world. But I dutifully went around and hit up every business in the local area. And I finally found this guy at a barber shop named Shear Madness, who was clearly high and was smoking a joint or a bong when I was there. I explained what we were doing, and I got him to sign up for a series of ads. I think he never actually paid because he came to his senses.

I recruited some buddies, Calvin Sims, who's now the CNN standards person. We got a little gang and I did all the editing myself, but my brother had trained me and I had two deputies, [CNN host] Fareed Zakaria and [former Slate editor-in-chief] Jacob Weisberg.

**WOW, THAT'S QUITE A TEAM.**

We published in the spring of my sophomore year a piece on the Non-Alignment Movement by this guy, Fareed Zakaria. I had no idea who he was. I literally wrote: "Fareed Zakaria, grew up in India." I think that was his first byline. We were not politically correct in those days.

The fall of my junior year, I got this call, saying, "Hi. This is Fareed Zakaria, I'd like to take you to lunch at Mory's." So we went to lunch at Mory's. And I say, "It's nice to meet you." He said, "Well, I've been thinking. I'm head of the Political Union. But that's a one-year position. And it's going to be over, and I was thinking about what I wanted to do next. And I decided that I would be editor of the magazine." To which my response was, "Well, I'm very glad you decided that, who the fuck are you?" So, all you need to know about Fareed Zakaria is two things. One, that he would say something like that, and two, that he would end up as the editor of the magazine.

Jacob and Fareed and I have remained close friends ever since and still regularly see each other. Fareed got editor-in-chief over Jacob because Jacob from his beginnings has always been a journalist. He would define himself that way. Fareed and I don't think of ourselves as journalists. We think of ourselves as God knows what — whatever pretentious thing you could imagine. I describe myself as a half-wonk, half-academic who happens to be a good editor. But journalist is not our primary identity, and I didn't think of the magazine as a place for journalism so much as I thought about it as a place like what we've tried to do with *Foreign Affairs* now — a high-end discussion forum for serious people to address topics of public interest in a clear, literate way.

I used to joke that if the truck bearing the copies from the press had gotten into a terrible accident on the highway coming from the printer, and blown up in a giant fireball with the entire run being destroyed, 90-95% of the value of the *YPM* magazine would still have been achieved. Because even though we thought that the value was all the great debate that we were sponsoring and the wonderful data, it was really the training that the people involved received. If we hadn't believed it was important, we would never have put all the fucking time and energy and late nights and endless passion into it that we did. And if we hadn't done that, we would never have developed the skills and learned the shit that we did that allowed us to become serious people later on.

# A CONVERSATION WITH Matthew Ellison

BY **AXEL DE VERNOU**

*Matthew Ellison '10 conducted interviews with a variety of experts for* The Politic *between 2007 and 2009. He went on to graduate from Georgetown University's Law Center in 2015, serving as a Legislative Assistant at the House of Representatives during his studies. Ellison then worked for the South Carolina Democratic Party before assuming various roles in the House, which now include being the Policy Director for the House Majority Whip and the Special Counsel to the Chairman for a Select Subcommittee on the Coronavirus Crisis.*

**DURING YOUR TIME AT *THE POLITIC*, IT SEEMS THAT YOU FOCUSED A LOT OF YOUR WRITING ON INTERVIEWS WITH GOVERNORS, PROFESSORS, AND DEANS. WHAT WAS THE LOGIC BEHIND THIS CHOICE AND HOW HAS IT HELPED YOU ACHIEVE YOUR PROFESSIONAL GOALS?**

It was a long time ago so it's hard to remember exactly what I was thinking when I pursued each one, much less a broader vision, but my recollection is that I focused on interviews with policymakers and other subjects who I thought would be interesting for me to hear from and would be a valuable contribution to the journal. They contributed to all the issues they appeared in in a positive way and, as I recall, I had positive experiences with virtually every interview I did for the magazine.

**COULD YOU ELABORATE A BIT ON YOUR EVERYDAY TASKS AS A POLICY DIRECTOR AND WHAT ULTIMATELY LED TO YOU ULTIMATELY FOCUS YOUR WORK ON THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES COMPARED TO ANOTHER BRANCH OF GOVERNMENT?**

Sure. I'll start with the second part. After I graduated from Yale, I was very fortunate to be hired as a Staff Assistant by the Majority Whip of the House, Jim Clyburn, who represents South Carolina, which is where I grew up. That was in 2010 when the Democrats were in the House Majority. I was fortunate to continue working for congressman Clyburn after we lost the majority in the 2010 elections.

I was able to attend law school at night at Georgetown while working for him as a legislative assistant. I went from purely administrative tasks as a Staff Assistant to working for policy issues as a young Legislative Assistant and continued on that role all throughout and after law school. I left in 2016 and was hired by Jaime Harrison, who, at the time, was the chair of the South Carolina Democratic Party. I served as Policy and Communications director of the party for a year. I ultimately found myself drawn back to DC and Capitol Hill, so I returned as Legislative Director for congresswoman Debbie Wasserman Schultz. When we retook the house majority in 2018, I returned as Deputy Policy Director for Congressman Clyburn's staff.

Then in 2020, when the coronavirus hit, Clyburn was appointed by the speaker as chairman for the Select Subcommittee of the Coronavirus Crisis and I took on the additional role as Special Counsel to the chairman. In my whip office role in the first year of the Biden administration, I was elevated to Policy Director. I've been in that position for the past several months.

My day-to-day routine really depends on the day. Some days I focus on my role in the majority whip's office, some days most of my tasks are taken up by my coronavirus select subcommittee duties. On the whip side, that's having meetings with constituents and other stakeholders, having meetings and conversations with other Hill staffers, preparing and sitting in meetings with congresspeople, preparing talking points, writing speeches, and working on legislation that we may be introducing. On the subcommittee side, that involves a lot of letters that we send as part of our investigation, preparing for hearings that we're holding, preparing talking points if the chairman is talking to the media or having meetings that pertain to the subcommittee's work.

**HOW DOES YOUR WORK ON THE SUBCOMMITTEE FIT INTO YOUR POLITICAL EXPERIENCE AND WHAT KIND OF NEW INSIGHT HAS IT GIVEN YOU ABOUT THE VIRUS BEYOND JUST A PURELY MEDICAL PHENOMENON?**

It has given me a front row seat to the political debate on the virus. We are continuing to investigate the ways in which the Trump administration prioritized politics over science in its pandemic response. That was something we observed and called out during his term.

Since the Biden administration has been in office, one thing I've learned in continuing to do this work is that, while it was clear in the Trump administration that there is a way not to follow the science, the science can only get you so far. We have to make decisions that involve difficult trade-offs involving public health, but also economics and ethics in a lot of ways. For example, the question of how to protect people against a virus who refuse every opportunity to get vaccinated is ultimately a very difficult public policy question that you really can't answer by simply saying that the science of the vaccine helps protect you against the coronavirus. Those are some of the issues we've been grappling with in order to continue advocating for policies that will protect people while recognizing that the virus will almost certainly remain a risk. We have to responsibly balance the steps we take to lower the risk as much as possible, just as we do with other risks like the flu and automobiles.

**THE PATH FROM BEING AN ASSISTANT TO MAKING IT TO THE U.S. HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES MUST HAVE REQUIRED AN ENORMOUS AMOUNT OF DEDICATION TO CERTAIN PRINCIPLES. WHAT OBJECTIVES OR VALUES DO YOU STRONGLY HOLD ON TO THAT HAVE GUIDED THE VARIOUS PARTS OF YOUR PROFESSIONAL CAREER?**

I've been very fortunate in my life to have amazing opportunities, an amazing education, and the chance to do the work I am doing. To the extent that I can really narrow down the basic values that have motivated me to do this work for the last 12 years, it really comes down to wanting everybody to have the same source of opportunities that I did.

**WITH AN ONGOING WAR IN EASTERN EUROPE AND INCREASED TALK OF THE RISE OF AUTHORITARIAN POWERS ACROSS THE GLOBE, MANY AMERICANS ARE LOOKING TO THE REINFORCEMENT OF DEMOCRACY TO PRESERVE THE RIGHTS OF CITIZENS. IN WHAT WAY DO YOU SEE THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES ADDRESSING THIS NEED?**

Well, it's a question that we're in the process of answering. That answer will develop as events develop. Yesterday, we took a first step since the conflict started by passing a resolution strongly condemning Russia's actions, calling for them to stop the war in Ukraine, and expressing our full support for the Ukrainian people. The administration has requested resources to support the people of Ukraine that I expect will be provided by Congress in some form— likely in a spending package— that we will soon pass. Beyond that I think it largely remains to be seen and will largely depend on the elements happening on the ground.

**SWITCHING BACK TO THE YALE COMMUNITY: IF YOU COULD OFFER ONE PIECE OF ADVICE TO CURRENT UNDERGRADUATES ABOUT THEIR POST-COLLEGE CAREER PATH, WHAT WOULD IT BE?**

Think about what you really want to do and do it. Yale students are incredibly fortunate to be able to make that assessment and pursue it in a way that a lot of other people aren't. Given that privilege, I think it is both likely to be personally fulfilling and good for others around them and for society. Yale students should think deliberately about how they will be most fulfilled and where they can do the most good.

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